

Ontological Investigations

Table of contents

1	Overview	10
	Preface	10
	Layered ontology	10
	Process ontology	11
	Dispositions and powers	12
	Probability and potentiality	13
	Physics	14
	Psychic level	14
	Spiritual	15
	Society	15
	Government	15
	Economics	15
2	Ontological Investigations	16
	Ontological Investigations	18
3	Preface	19
I	Foundation	21
1	Why a critical ontology?	22
	1.1 Entities, spheres and strata	23
	1.2 “Dasein” and “Sosein”	26
	1.2.1 Translation	27

1.3	Conclusion	28
2	Strata of being	30
3	Objects in a Field of Sense	36
3.1	Defining the Field of Sense	36
3.2	Gabriel's Original Ontology	37
3.3	Proposed Modification: "The World is not an Object"	37
3.3.1	The Revised Logical Scheme:	38
3.4	Categorization and Reference	39
3.5	Conclusion	39
4	Ontological Framework: Nicolai Hartmann and Quantum Mechanics	40
4.1	Ontological status of quantum substratum	41
5	Hartmann and Hayek: A Comparative Ontology	44
5.1	Introduction	44
5.2	Hartmann's Stratified Ontology	45
5.2.1	Levels of Reality	45
5.2.2	The Categorical <i>Novum</i>	45
5.2.3	Dependence Relations	46
5.3	Hayek's Emergentist Ontology	46
5.3.1	The Sensory Order	46
5.3.2	Complex Phenomena and Spontaneous Order	46
5.3.3	Anti-Reductionism	47
5.4	Structural Parallels Between Hartmann and Hayek	47
5.4.1	Levels vs. Orders	47
5.4.2	Novum vs. Spontaneous Order	48
5.4.3	Dependence and Constraint	48
5.4.4	Realism About Higher-Level Entities	48
5.5	Differences and Tensions	48
5.5.1	Systematic vs. Fragmentary Ontology	48

5.5.2	Normativity	49
5.5.3	Methodological Divergence	49
5.6	A Hartmannian Reconstruction of Hayek	49
5.6.1	Mapping Hayek into Hartmann's Framework	49
5.6.2	Strengthening Hayek's Anti-Reductionism	49
5.6.3	Implications for Social Ontology	50
5.7	Conclusion	50
6	Taking process philosophy seriously	51
6.1	The Philosophical Landscape - physical layer	51
6.2	Alternative Mechanisms	52
6.3	The Whiteheadian Scheme	52
6.4	Key Terms in Process and Reality	53
6.4.1	Flow diagram of key terms	55
II	Dispositions and powers	56
1	The ontology of dispositions	57
1.1	The Ontology of Dispositions and Objective Chance	57
1.1.1	Intuitive vs. Quantum Dispositions	58
1.1.2	Popper and Propensity	59
1.1.3	Properties and Fields of Sense	59
1.1.4	Summary of Ontological Position	61
2	Concepts of causal powers	62
2.1	Activity	63
2.2	Capacity	64
2.3	Essence	65
2.4	Necessitation	65
2.5	Conclusion	66

III	Probability and potentiality	68
1	Potentiality and Probability	69
1.1	Tendencies	70
1.1.1	Example (adapted from Anjum and Mumford)	71
1.2	Initial Discussion of Probability	72
1.3	Probability vs. Necessity	74
1.3.1	The Rai Stone Example	76
1.4	Probabilities and Chance	77
1.5	Radioactive Decay and Quantum Theory	78
1.6	Conclusion	80
2	The Kolmogorov probability axioms and objective chance	82
2.1	Subjective vs. Objective Probability	82
2.2	The Suárez Formulation	83
2.3	The Kolmogorov Formulation	84
2.3.1	Mapping Logic to Set Theory	85
2.4	A Reformulated Neutral Axiom Set	86
2.5	Applications: The Die and the Electron	87
2.6	Conclusion	88
3	Conditional probability: Renyi versus Kolmogorov	89
IV	Physical layer	96
1	A Relational Reconstruction of Quantum Mechanics	97
1.0.1	Proposition	100
2	Heisenberg, Potentiality, and Quantum Ontology	101
2.1	Possibility and Iterated Potentiality	106
2.2	Joint Potentiality	107

2.3	Extrinsic Potentiality	108
2.4	Iterated Potentiality	108
2.5	Formalising Potentiality	109
2.6	The Electron	110
3	The double slit experiment	112
3.1	Standard configuration	113
3.2	The introduction of an interaction with a pointer	115
3.3	Treatment I: Pointer reacts to which slit the electron passes through	118
3.4	Treatment II: Pointer does <i>not</i> react to which slit the electron passes through	119
4	Locality, Microcausality, and Entanglement	121
4.1	Causal Locality	122
4.2	Entanglement and Non-Locality	125
5	Comparison of quantum physical ontologies	132
5.1	Local beables	133
5.2	Wavefunction ontology	134
	5.2.1 Distributed charge and mass	135
	5.2.2 The multiverse	136
5.3	Bohmian ontology	137
5.4	Conclusion	139
6	Introduction to Physical Ontology	140
6.1	The Problem of Contextuality	140
6.2	Position, Momentum, and the Field of Sense . . .	141
6.3	Mathematical Formulation of Spin	142
	6.3.1 Spin Operators and Pauli Matrices	142
6.4	Spin Eigenvalues and State Vectors	143
6.5	Non-Commutativity and Interaction	144

7	The Combination of Quantum Objects	145
8	Quantum chance	147
8.1	Quantum States	147
8.1.1	Probability Measures	147
8.1.2	Pure and Mixed States	149
8.2	Properties or Observables	150
8.3	Symmetries	151
8.3.1	Conditional States	153
8.3.2	Total Probability in Classical and Quantum Conditional Probability	154
8.4	Summary	156
9	Modal categories and quantum chance	157
9.1	Introduction	157
9.2	The Hierarchy of Modal Categories	157
9.2.1	Positive Modes of Being	158
9.2.2	Negative Modes of Being	158
9.3	Modal Profiles of Quantum Interpretations	159
9.3.1	Standard Quantum Mechanics	159
9.3.2	Bohmian Mechanics	159
9.3.3	Ghirardi–Rimini–Weber (GRW) Theory	160
9.3.4	The “Many-Worlds” Description	161
9.3.5	Summary Matrix	161
9.4	3. Quantum Chance and the Problem of Actual- ization	162
10	The Quantum Mechanics of Events, Histories and Trees	164
10.1	<i>Gemini feedback</i>	164
10.2	1. Foundations vs. Interpretation (Credo 1 & 2)	164
10.3	2. The Ontological Friction: What Constitutes “What Is”? (Credo 3)	165
10.3.1	Bridging the Gap	165

10.4	3. Mathematical Rigor as an Epistemic Guardrail (Credo 4 & 5)	166
10.5	Moving Forward: The Horizon of ETH	166
10.6	End of feedback	167
11	The Impossibility of Prediction and Quantum Indeterminacy	173
11.1	Impossibility of Prediction	173
11.2	Indeterminacy of Quantum Mechanics	175
12	Events in quantum mechanics: a simple proposal	178
	Experiments examined	178
12.1	Proposal	179
	Toy model (two-level system coupled to a pointer)	180
12.2	Remarks and context	181
12.3	Development avenues	182
12.4	Suggested additions for a fuller manuscript	183
V	Psychic layer	184
1	Sensory order	185
1.1	Emergence and layers	186
2	Hartmann and Hayek on layered reality	187
2.1	Ontological levels	187
2.2	Emergence and the “novum”	188
2.3	Dependence and constraint	188
2.4	Anti-reductionism	189
2.5	Rules, categories, and order	189
2.6	Realism about higher-level entities	190
2.7	Key differences	190

VI	Spiritual layer	192
1	Ontological Critiques of the Notion of Government	193
1.1	Introduction	193
1.2	Anti-Entity Critiques: Government as a Reified Abstraction	194
1.3	Process-Ontology Critiques: Government as a Set of Practices	194
1.4	Social-Constructivist Critiques: Government as a Status Function	195
1.5	Normative-Ontological Critiques: The Incoherence of Political Authority	196
1.6	Conclusion	196
VII	End	198
1	References	199

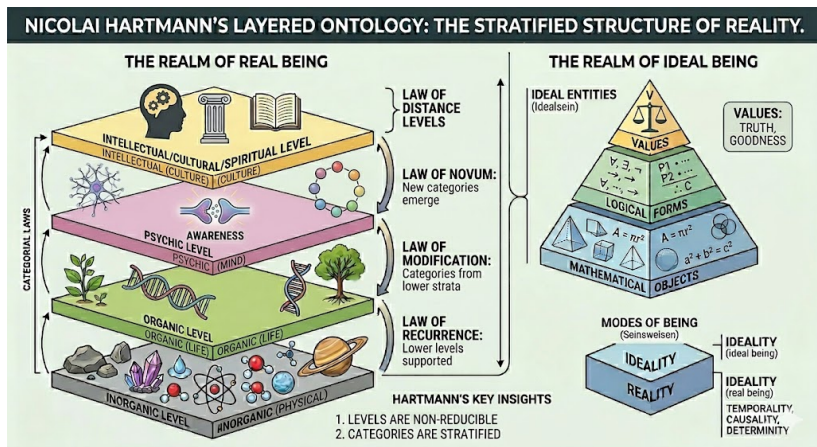
1 Overview

These investigations will be organised in sections and chapters. The structure is that of an online book that is a work in progress.

The assistance of Gemini is acknowledged for the illustrations and formatting.

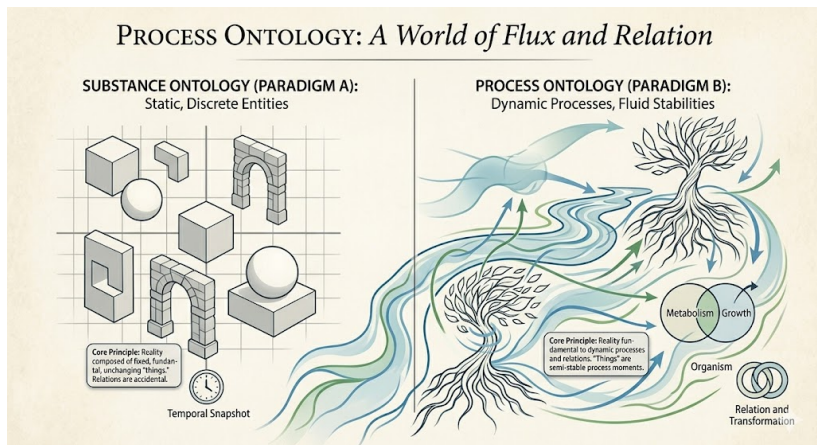
Preface

Layered ontology



- Why critical ontology?
- Strata of being
- Objects in a Field of Sense
- Ontological Framework: Nicolai Hartmann and Quantum Mechanics
- Hartmann and Hayek: A Comparative Ontology

Process ontology



- Taking process philosophy seriously

Dispositions and powers

THE ONTOLOGICAL RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN DISPOSITIONS AND POWERS

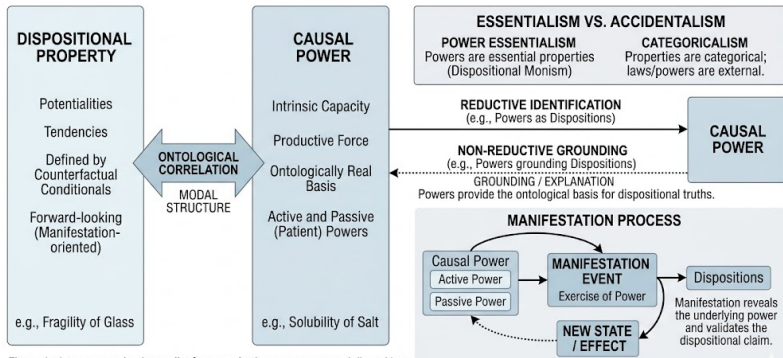
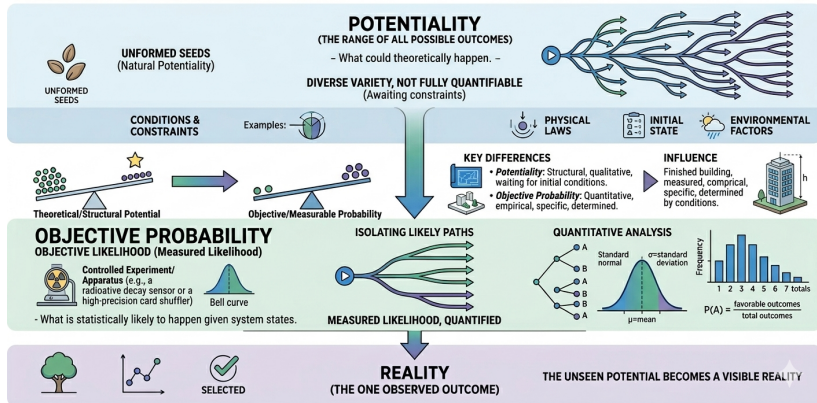


Figure depicts a **non-reductive realist framework** where powers ground dispositions.
Diagram based on contemporary metaphysics discussions (e.g., Molnar, Mumford, Bird, Lowe).

- The ontology of dispositions
- Concepts of causal powers

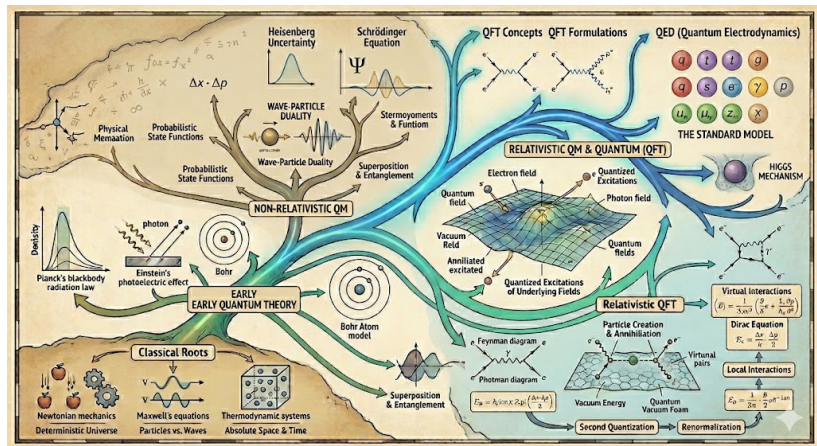
Probability and potentiality

THE SPECTRUM OF THE POSSIBLE: POTENTIALITY VS. OBJECTIVE PROBABILITY



- Potentiality and probability
- The Kolmogorov probability axioms and objective chance
- Conditional probability: Renyi versus Kolmogorov

Physics



- A relational reconstruction of Quantum Mechanics
- Heisenberg, Potentiality, and Quantum Ontology
- The double slit experiment
- Locality and quantum mechanics
- Comparison of quantum physical ontologies
- Ontology and the quantum object
- The combination of quantum objects
- Quantum chance
- Modal categories and quantum chance
- The Quantum Mechanics of Events, Histories and Trees
- Prediction, indeterminacy, and randomness
- Events in quantum mechanics

Psychic level

- Sensory order

Spiritual

- [Hartmann and Hayek](#)

Society

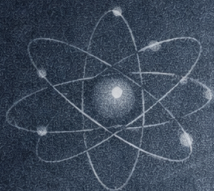
Government

- [Ontological Critiques of the Notion of Government](#)

Economics

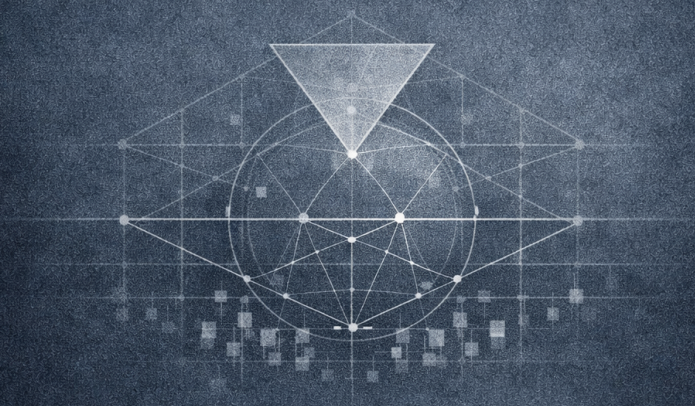
2 Ontological Investigations

From Physics to Social Structures



ONTOLOGICAL INVESTIGATIONS

From Physics to Social Structures



Robert Johnston

Ontological Investigations

From Physics to Social Structures

Robert Johnston

3 Preface

The “being” of things is indifferent to whatever things might be “for someone”.

This book will look at a series of ontological challenges and solutions ranging from physical foundations to the contents of cultures.

My guiding principle is that entities have properties and interactions that are independent of whatever anyone or anything knows about them. Experiments are for finding out about the physical world not for instantiating it. That is, the physical world is there even when no one is looking. The discussion will engage with ontologies that deal with an autonomous physical world independent of considerations of what is known about the system or who is interfering with it. However, opposing views will also be considered.

There are quantum theories that focus on what can be known about a physical system rather than what the systems behaviour is *per se*. The original Copenhagen interpretation of quantum mechanics falls into this category, but a more recent approach is Quantum Bayesianism. Commonly shortened to *QBism*, it interprets the quantum state as capturing a degree of belief. There are questions about the ontological assumptions associated with the theory, with options ranging from a form of idealism to “participatory realism”.

The New Ontology by Nicolai Hartmann (1949a) provides a structure of ontological strata and spheres of being. This structure is similar to but much richer than Karl Popper's three-world ontology (Popper 1972).

Part I

Foundation

1 Why a critical ontology?

**“Das Sein des Seienden ist indifferent gegen das, was das Seiende ‘für jemanden’ ist.”* (Hartmann 1948)

“The ‘being’ of things is indifferent to whatever things might be ‘for someone’.”

Nicolai Hartmann asked “How is a critical ontology at all possible?” (Hartmann 1924). He was writing at a time when metaphysics was under attack or being dismissed as irrelevant. Part of his answer was that ontology, properly structured, is more like a science of what exists than speculative metaphysics. Critical ontology is a way of investigating what exists and how it exists and that this investigation must be considered before turning to how things behave. Hartmann’s writings on ontology (Hartmann 1948), (Hartmann 1937), (Hartmann 1939), (Hartmann 1949b), developed this answer further. In addition to taking seriously the phenomena of normal life and natural science, he examined in detail the history of ontology. Hartmann’s critical historical examination, ranging from the pre-socratics to his contemporaries such as Heidegger, leads him to classify many approaches as mistaken in not addressing existence as such but merely the appearance or knowledge of things. He also argued that assigning all entities to either the realm of ideas or physical substance is a fundamental mistake.

Critical ontology is a phrase used elsewhere, but in a different sense. For example, as the branch of philosophy that studies what it means to be in the world as human. This has given rise to critical studies in the social sciences and identity politics. Our use of “critical” has nothing to do with critical studies or critical theory or any of its derivatives. Critical in this investigation means a stance or approach that examines theories, claims and proposals for consistency and correspondence with the facts together with a recognition that there is always the possibility of error. This comprehensive fallibilism should apply to all investigations but will be explicitly recognised in this one.

In addition to critical historical investigation, ontology needs some terminology and structure. Hartmann’s concepts of *heterogeneous ontic spheres* and *strata* provide a starting point for this set of investigations but they will not escape critique either.

1.1 Entities, spheres and strata

The phrase *What is as such* will be taken as the point of departure. The term “entity” will be used for what is. An entity - purely as such, whatever it may be in its particulars - exists indifferently to whether it is known or not known, whether it is knowable or unknowable. Without entities there would be nothing to have properties, to make appearances nor to induce perceptions. The object is related to the entity and is used when the entity stands in relation to another entity. That is, it becomes an object through relationship.

The philosophical task of organising what exists into categories can be traced back to Aristotle, at least, and ‘object’ is a candidate for the category under which everything falls but so, perhaps,

is “thing” or “entity”. Nominal definitions can only provide an arbitrary distinction between the terms and so do not provide progress. Rather than just formally fixing definitions use will be made of intuition from normal usage, that will provide guidance on the distinctions to be adopted:

- “Entity” will be used to designate that which exists as such. *Enties will have there own particular way of being.*
- “Thing” can designate a physical entity. *Contrary to some physicalist ontologies not all entites are things.*
- An “object” is an entity that has properties, and these properties appear in relation to other entities.

In physical theories the entities of interest will be things that are objects. As we will see in our discussion of quantum physics, what makes an oject physical will require development of the concept. What is achieved by insisting on the “entity” is to stress that existence is not merely a matter of appearance. Appearance only provides access to the object. This notion of appearance is interactional and reflexive. In particular, quantum particles such as electrons, protons and positrons are objects and it is through their properties that they interact with other objects, and it is their properties that are observables in the sense of *standard quantum mechanics*. However, there are aspects to them being *things* that will mean extending the physical from things in space andtime.

The ontological structures introduced by Hartmann include:

- The ideal sphere of being
- The real sphere of being
- The layered structure of real being.
- The Dasein and Sosein relationship.

A major purpose of Hartmann's ontology is to clarify the mistakes and pitfalls in idealism and realism. These "isms" will make the dogmatic claim that fundamentally everything is either immaterial (Ideal) or everything physical (Real). Critical ontology makes clear that there is no need to follow either dogmatic path but claims it is wrong to identify the real with the material. The real sphere is much larger.

The ideal sphere includes entities such as logic, mathematics, scientific theories. It is also the sphere where ethical and aesthetic values reside. The ideal and real spheres are not separate forms of existence but different ways of being. This is a position going back to Plato who argued that ideal being is superior to material being and more real because eternal. In contrast Hartmann argues that the real (as set out below) is the ontologically stronger sphere. The two spheres are distinguished in that everything real is individual, unique, destructible; whereas everything ideal is universal, returnable, always existing.

The real sphere consists of the natural world of common experience and its elaboration through scientific investigation. This sphere has four layers or strata (Schichten): inorganic, organic, psychic, and spiritual.

- **Inorganic stratum**, with categories such as space, time, process, substance, is organised through causality.
- **Organic stratum**, with categories such as metabolism, assimilation, self-regulation, self-reproduction and adaptation, is organically organised - the peculiarity of the organic network is unrecognizable for the time being.
- **Psychic stratum**, with categories such as consciousness, pleasure, act and content. Equally unknown is the form of determination of mental acts. That is, currently, we do not understand how mind works.

- **Spiritual stratum**, that includes categories of fear, hope, will, freedom, thought, personality, but also society, historicity, or intersubjectivity. Its organisation principle is, according to Hartmann, Finality Hartmann (1949a) page 58. In this layer and in the psychic we are all players and this changes what a method of scientific exploration of being is going to be. The work of Hayek will provide a starting point for such deliberations (Hayek 1952)

Note: *Spirit* is employed here in the sense of the German term *Geist* that originates from the German idealist tradition influenced by Hegel among others. However it is also used in standard German. For example, in Geisteswissenschaft (Humanities)—and its meaning covers both individual mind as well as superindividual culture, which is why it lacks an adequate English translation. It need not be interpreted in any religious sense here. In addition, “psychic” relates to mind and mental - no interpretation in terms of occult “psychic phenomena” is intended.

In the stratified structure the organic layer builds on the inorganic and the psychic builds on the organic. It is only through the system of categories that apply to them that distinguish the levels. The relationship between the strata and their categories requires systemic treatment and will be covered in a separate chapter.

1.2 “Dasein” and “Sosein”

“Dasein” and “Sosein” (“being there” and “being so” although the original German will be used in the following translation) are

interacting ways of being in both spheres. This is illustrated by a quotation from Hartmann (1948) page 123:

Das Dasein des Baumes an seiner Stelle “ist” selbst ein Sosein des Waldes, der Wald wäre anders ohne ihn; das Dasein des Astes am Baum “ist” ein Sosein des Baumes; das Dasein des Blattes am Aste “ist” ein Sosein des Astes; das Dasein der Rippe im Blatt “ist” ein Sosein des Blattes. Diese Reihe läßt sich nach beiden Seiten verlängern; immer ist das Dasein des einen zugleich Sosein des anderen. Aber sie läßt sich auch umkehren: das Sosein des Blattes “ist” das Dasein der Rippe, das Sosein des Astes ist das Dasein des Blattes usf. Daß es immer nur ein Bruchstück des Soseins ist, das im Dasein von etwas anderem besteht, daran wird man hierbei keinen Anstoß nehmen dürfen. Denn es handelt sich gar nicht um die Vollständigkeit des Soseins. Wohl aber läßt sich sagen, daß auch die übrigen Bruchstücke des Soseins auf dieselbe Weise im Dasein von immer wieder anderem und anderem bestehen.

1.2.1 Translation

The Dasein of the tree in its place “is” itself a Sosein of the forest, the forest would be different without it; the Dasein of the branch on the tree “is” a Sosein of the tree; the Dasein of the leaf on the branch “is” a Sosein of the branch; the Dasein of the rib in the leaf “is” a Sosein of the leaf. This series can be extended to both sides; always the Dasein of one is at the same time Sosein of the other. But it can also be reversed: the

Sosein of the leaf “is” the Dasein of the rib, the Sosein of the branch is the Dasein of the leaf, etc. That it is always only a fragment of the Soseins, which consists in the Dasein of something else, must not be taken negatively. Because it is not at all about the completeness of being. But it can be said that the other fragments of Sosein also exist in the repeating existence of always different and different things.

1.3 Conclusion

For the purpose of this investigation what Hartmann’s world provides is not a philosophical system but a way of investigating *being* systematically. It is critically constructive. Step by step, we can gain greater insight into the constituents of the world. In this investigation topics will be tackled in physical and social science as well as philosophy where ambiguity over what exists or dogmatic positions risk hiding the nature of what there is and how it acts. For example, in physics, the status of space and time has been debated for millennia. Some claim that one or the other or both are illusory. In economics homo economicus is often declared not to exist but can be found in many text books.

It is the current debate on the foundations of quantum mechanics on the status of the wavefunction and the particle that rekindled my interest in ontological questions. So quantum physics will have a number of chapters devoted to it and be referred to throughout this investigation.

Hartmann’s philosophy will provide the initial structure for these ontological investigations. A very useful and concise introduc-

tion to Hartmann's philosophy as whole is provided by Predrag Cicovacki in *The Analysis of Wonder* (Cicovacki 2014).

2 Strata of being

To discuss ontology in general and to compare competing ontological proposals some structure is useful. This structure will help to place *candidate beings* in relation to others, understand their way of being and, for example, avoid the category mistake of identifying elements of physical reality with their mathematical representation. Here we will explore the proposal that reality is indeed stratified and secondly what that stratification may be. In *critical ontology* it will be important to distinguish whether these levels are levels of reality *per se* or levels in a description of reality.

The starting point cannot just be comprehensive scepticism about whether anything exists or not. That will get us nowhere. We will start by taking the phenomena around us as they appear. There appear to be things that take up space and are stable. There appear to be things that take space and grow. There are appear to be things that have some purpose and make choices. There appear to be things that are made up of other things. In addition, there are beings with emotional states and awareness of making choices. There is also awareness of resistance or pushback from other things. There is awareness of being the capacity of some beings to change the state of other things. We may be mistaken about particular things and their relationship to each other but the appearances are the appearances. In talking about things and beings, we have implicitly used categories such as a space, time,

choice, emotion, awareness and substance. The categories will play an important role in characterising the levels in which beings exist. There will be a separate chapter on categories. Hartmann proposes a pluralistic view of reality, that covers all the things and beings listed above, that appear in four dynamically interrelated *strata* (Cicovacki 2014):

1. Inorganic
2. Organic
3. Psychic
4. Spiritual.

The layers are presented in the order of decreasing ontological strength. That is, in each layer the beings depend on those in stronger layers to exist. However, the beings in the less strong layers cannot be reduced to beings in stronger layers. They have their specific categories of existence. There are also multi *strata* beings as will be illustrated at the end of this chapter. The question of whether these levels exist and the nature of their existence will not be examined here other than to recognise them as structural proposals and so will be seen to at least exist at the *spiritual level*.

The name given to each level is not problematic except for the fourth. *Spiritual being* is a translation from the German *geistige Sein* and the use of the term Geist follows the tradition influenced by Hegel and Dilthey - as it is used, for example, in Geisteswissenschaft, and its meaning covers both individual mind as well as superindividual culture, which is why it lacks an adequate English translation. No religious sense of the term is intended here. Beings at the spiritual level cannot exist without the other levels.

Although the listing of the four *strata* suggests a hierarchy, to

provide this thought with some substance something needs to be said about the relationship between the strata. The levels of reality are characterised (and therefore distinguished) by their categories. With regard to the levels of reality, it is obvious that the categories in question are ontological rather than epistemological. There are categories that pertain to reality as whole - such as time, whole, part. At the inorganic level the categories of physics are different from those of chemistry. Some examples follow.

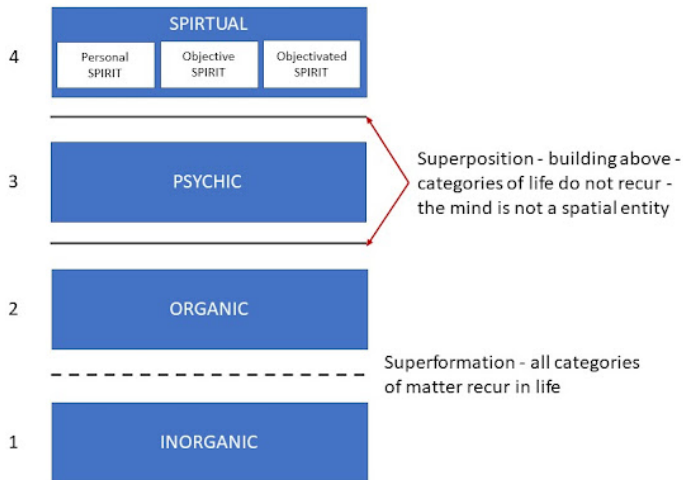
1. Inorganic stratum, with categories such as space, time, process, substance, is organised through causality.
2. Organic stratum, with categories such as metabolism, assimilation, self-regulation, self-reproduction and adaptation, is organically organised - the details of the organising principles are unknown for the time being.
3. The psychic stratum, with categories such as consciousness, pleasure, act and content, has its own psychic network of relations. Equally unknown is the inner essence of the form of determination of mental acts.
4. Spirit includes categories of fear, hope, will, freedom, thought, personality, but also society, historicity, or intersubjectivity. It is organised as three modes of spirit;
 - Personal - thought, freedom, conscious action and moral will
 - Objective - superindividual but living as culture, collective or society
 - Objectivated - superindividually existing but non-living. As in cultural artifacts and institutions.

All categories at the inorganic level, such as space and time, recur at the organic level. This recurrence of categories is called *super-information*. There is also autonomy off levels and this is known as *superposition* - building above. For example, *consciousness*, a category of the psyche, is not spatial.

In addition there are the “fundamental” categories (common for all strata of real being) that come in pairs: principle–concretum; structure–modus; form–matter; inner–outer; determination–dependence; quality–quantity; unity–manifoldness; harmony–conflict; contrast–dimension; discretion–continuity; substratum–relation; element–structure.

The above only provides a sketch. For more detail on the categories of real being see Cicovacki (2014) who provides a bridge to the detailed work by Hartmann.

The basic structure can be summarised in a diagram.



Hartmann's model of reality includes mind and spirit superposed on an ontologically stronger foundation of life and matter. There is, however, a feedback loop that is not explicit in the diagram. The objectivated spirit gives rise to artifacts, such as books and architecture, that are also actualised as things at the material level. For example, a person, James Joyce say, has some thoughts (personal spirit) about Dublin society (objective spirit) and creates a novel, *Ulysses* (objectivated spirit), that is published as book (still objectivated spirit) and printed in several editions (inorganic objects).

The being James Joyce was made of inorganic matter organised as an inorganic life form with a mind and emotional life on which was superposed a spirit that could choose to work for years on intricate works of literature. He would also often choose to drink

heavily after a day's work. He loved his immediate family.

A further example. This documentation of this investigation exists as objectivated spirit. It came into being because of my choice and was enabled by the infrastructure supplied by the web. Making and maintaining the documentation are choices made by me at the level of my personal spirit. The physical document is dependent on organised matter (inorganic level) the organisation of it is objectivated spirit because it was designed. The document and its chapters are captured and encoded in the infrastructure. The chapters may be instantiated on the screen of a reader's device. The readers use their sense organs and brain (organic level) to access the information that is processed through their psychic level and, hopefully, understood at the level of their personal spirit. The readers and I form a loose community that exists as objective spirit.

Simple beings such as electrons may only inhabit the inorganic level but the existence of complex beings may be across many or all strata. This complex existence is a process rather than a hierarchy.

3 Objects in a Field of Sense

Within the layers and spheres described in **Hartmann’s architecture for critical ontology**, there is scope for introducing further structure. A **Field of Sense** (Gabriel 2015) is an organizational concept that can be employed within a layer or within a sphere.

While Gabriel’s full ontology cannot be accepted within the critical ontology adopted from Hartmann, a *Field of Sense* remains a potentially useful concept. It fits with Hartmann’s distinction of item and object. An object is an item that appears in the context of other items. Some of these other items become objects in their turn. Entities become objects in a Field of Sense.

3.1 Defining the Field of Sense

A Field of Sense is a domain in which objects appear in relationship to each other. The nature of these appearances depends on the properties of the objects involved.

- **Example:** A cube of ice melting on a table in a warm living room.
- The **living room** , with all its other objects, is the Field of Sense.

- The **table, air, and ice** are some of the objects appearing within it.
- **Recursive Structure:** The living room can itself be an object within a larger Field of Sense, such as **the house**.

3.2 Gabriel's Original Ontology

For Gabriel, the mode of existence of an object depends entirely on the Field of Sense that grants it. In this view:

- **Existence:** To exist is to appear in a Field of Sense (belonging to a domain of appearance).
- **Sense:** Derived from Frege (Frege 1962), Gabriel generalizes “sense” from the grasping of a concept to the context that makes an appearance possible.
- **Example:** The “Morning Star” and “Evening Star” are two senses of the object Venus.
- **The Negative Result:** Gabriel argues that the “World” (the totality of all that exists) would have to be the Field of Sense of all Fields of Sense. Since it cannot appear within a larger field, Gabriel concludes that **the World does not exist**.

3.3 Proposed Modification: “The World is not an Object”

The following modification is proposed to address the critique that existence is not strictly synonymous with appearance. While

objects appear in fields that consist of other entities, appearance may not exhaust the meaning of “existing.” Hartmann already reserves the term “object” for an entity that exists in relation to other entities.

3.3.1 The Revised Logical Scheme:

1. **Appearance:** The properties of all objects appear in a Field of Sense.
2. **Sense:** A sense is the specific way in which an object appears.
3. **Recursion:** A Field of Sense can be an object in yet another Field of Sense.
4. **Relationality:** A Field of Sense must contain multiple objects; appearance is always a relationship.
5. **Totality:** The world cannot be an object in a Field of Sense (otherwise it would require a larger field to appear in).
6. **Definition of Objecthood:** To be an **object** is to appear in a Field of Sense.
7. **Conclusion:** Therefore, **the World is not an object.**

Note: This eliminates Gabriel’s paradox. The World exists as the systematic totality, but because it has no “outside” entity to relate to, it cannot be categorized as an *object*.

3.4 Categorization and Reference

- **Scope of Existence:** The physical universe, people, scientific theories, and fictional characters all exist in at least one Field of Sense.
- **Reference:** Fields of Sense are differentiated by reference (Frege 1962). Reference enables the recognition of the field in which an object appears, preventing “reference mistakes” (e.g., mistaking a TV play for one’s actual family life).

3.5 Conclusion

By shifting the headline result from “*The World does not exist*” to “*The World is not an object,*” we maintain ontological realism. This allows for investigation within and across **Hartmann’s strata** (Inorganic, Organic, Psychic, and Spiritual) and both ontic spheres without the paradox of Gabriel’s radical stance.

4 Ontological Framework: Nicolai Hartmann and Quantum Mechanics

The ontological framework for this blog is from Nicolai Hartmann's *new ontology programme* that was developed in a number of very substantial publications in the first half of the 20th century. In my interpretation of it, it is the open and pluralistic nature of Hartmann's new ontology that is most attractive. It can include categories of substance, process, organism, consciousness and more. Its layer structure allows the discussion of emergence of multiple entities and supervenience, whatever the ultimate ontological status of the layer model. The openness and pluralism is more important to me than the layered ontology. However, many chapters are specifically about quantum mechanics. Quantum mechanics was already making confirmed predictions when Hartmann was writing, and he provided some analysis, but, did not get much further than identifying that quantum mechanics would provide some ontological challenges. In Hartmann's layered ontological model the foundation is the inorganic stratum, with categories such as space, time, process and substance.

At one stage it was thought that the challenges of quantum mechanics could have a solution in epistemology. However, the problem was that the physics is incomplete and so the problem was not just that of interpretation. The ontological status of the

theory can not be fully addressed without repairing the physics. The major flaw in standard quantum mechanics, as discussed in other chapters, is that there is no physical explanation of events.

As a theory that includes a physical explanation of events, consider Ruth Kastner's relativistic transactional interpretation (RTI) (Kastner 2022) as a working theory that plugs the holes in the physics that were the main concern. For ontological analysis, the most significant aspect of RTI is the nature of the quantum substratum and its relationship with the empirical domain. Ruth Kastner does address metaphysical issues but here an independent view will be presented. The analysis of the physics is for a universe that *is* independent of a knowing subject (Popper 1972).

4.1 Ontological status of quantum substratum

The quantum substratum is a domain of potentiality. It is not only not observable; it is not actual. The only indicator of its nature is the mathematical theory that relates it to actual events. This mathematical theory could be treated as a mere prediction and technology instrument. However I want to examine how the universe could be in itself. The potentiality substratum is real in that it is the source of physical events.

A potentiality interpretation of quantum mechanics is not an innovation of RTI. It was proposed by Heisenberg (Heisenberg 1958) and is championed by researchers who do not adopt RTI (Kastner et al. 2018). The three authors, it seems, could not agree with Ruth Kastner on adopting RTI as the best current explanation. The other authors are strongly influenced by A

N Whitehead's process metaphysics (Whitehead 2010). On a first pass, a metaphysics with a fundamental event and process ontology, such as Whitehead's, seems consistent with RTI. however, there are many details and interpretations of Whitehead's metaphysics that I have yet to engage with.

In RTI events take place due to a transaction process in the substratum. Processes in the quantum substratum are disposed to create events that manifest in space-time and shape the future potential manifestation of events (objective quantum state reduction). The process can be summarised:

1. The physical system, described by relativistic quantum mechanics, evolves to a state that is favourable to a set of possible transactions.
2. The context of these possible transactions (at a given time in the substratum dynamics) and the state of the system defines a complete set of transition probabilities from a complex of incommensurable possible transitions.
3. One of the possible transitions takes place. This is, as far as the mathematical description guides, a physical stochastic process step.
4. The outcome is a space-time event and a change in the substratum state conditioned on that event.

Why should a quantum substratum of pure potentiality give rise to space-time events? In the mathematical structure describing the physics of the substratum time is a category and, space and momentum are among the potentialities. It would be conceivable that events would appear in a space-time block universe. Alternatively it is the relationship among the events that constitute space-time (Kastner 2022). Space-time is emergent and not ontological fundamental if the events are the elements of its fabric. Fundamentally there are no substances. For example, quantum

states describing electrons represent entities that cannot exhibit all their potential attributes at the same times. The picture in which quantum mechanics is a modification of classical mechanics that can keep the substance-particle as the fundamental ontology is no longer defensible. Classically Matter is fundamental, now, in the quantum description adopted here, matter-like entities emerge in a dynamic network of event relationships. This is a profound ontological innovation even greater than the introduction of electromagnetic fields.

Whatever the final status of a layered ontology turns out to be, I think that it will be useful in examining how, in detail, a substratum of pure potentiality can give rise to a rich world of physics, biology, psychology, society and culture.

5 Hartmann and Hayek: A Comparative Ontology

5.1 Introduction

This section examines the ontological parallels between **Nicolai Hartmann** and **Friedrich A. Hayek**.

Although there is no historical evidence of influence either way, their philosophies converge on three major themes:

- a **layered** or **stratified** structure of reality
- **emergence** and the irreducibility of higher levels
- **anti-reductionism** as a metaphysical position

The critical ontology of Hartmann was developed with the ambition to be a complete ontology that would set the way of being for all entites. Hayek is known as an economist. But, in addition to his technical work in economics he had wider interest in socail science and psynology. Hayek did not declare that his work in these areas is explicitly ontological and it s certainly not narrowly so. His work often has an epistemological flavour but his his emergent orders in what Harmann calls the *Psychical* and *Spiritual* layers provide a mechanism to explain how new entites

come into existence. The goal is to show how Hartmann's systematic ontology can illuminate and strengthen Hayek's emergentist psychological and social ontologies.

Key sources include Hartmann's *Der Aufbau der realen Welt* Hartmann (1940) and Hayek's *The Sensory Order* Hayek (1952), as well as recent secondary literature such as Lewis's analysis of Hayek's ontology (Lewis 2017).

5.2 Hartmann's Stratified Ontology

5.2.1 Levels of Reality

As previously discussed Hartmann distinguishes four major [strata](#):

1. **Inorganic**
2. **Organic**
3. **Psychic**
4. **Spiritual**

Each level has its own **categories, laws, and forms of determination**.

Higher levels depend on lower ones but are not reducible to them Hartmann (1953).

5.2.2 The Categorical *Novum*

Hartmann's doctrine of the *novum* states that higher levels introduce **genuinely new properties**.

This emergence is **ontological**, not merely epistemic.

5.2.3 Dependence Relations

Hartmann articulates several forms of dependence:

- **Foundation (Fundierung)**
- **Superstructure**
- **Autonomy of levels**

These relations allow for **asymmetric dependence**: the higher requires the lower, but the lower is not determined by the higher.

5.3 Hayek's Emergentist Ontology

5.3.1 The Sensory Order

In *The Sensory Order* Hayek (1952), Hayek argues that mental phenomena form a **classification system** that emerges from neural events but cannot be reduced to them.

This is Hayek's most explicit ontological work.

5.3.2 Complex Phenomena and Spontaneous Order

Hayek's social theory—developed in *Studies in Philosophy, Politics and Economics* Hayek (1967) and *Law, Legislation and Liberty* Hayek (1973)—treats markets, legal systems, and traditions as **higher-level orders**.

These orders:

- arise from individual interactions
- exhibit properties not predictable from micro-data
- constrain and guide individual behaviour

5.3.3 Anti-Reductionism

Hayek rejects both:

- **physicalist reduction** of mind
- **individualist reduction** of social institutions

His anti-reductionism is grounded in the **limits of knowledge** and the **structure of complex orders**.

5.4 Structural Parallels Between Hartmann and Hayek

5.4.1 Levels vs. Orders

Hartmann's *Schichtenbau der Welt* and Hayek's theory of complex orders both posit:

- hierarchical structures
- emergent properties
- irreducible higher-level regularities

5.4.2 Novum vs. Spontaneous Order

Hartmann's *categorical novum* parallels Hayek's idea that higher-level orders exhibit **new patterns** not derivable from lower-level data.

5.4.3 Dependence and Constraint

Both philosophers endorse **asymmetric dependence**:

- higher levels/orders depend on lower ones
- once formed, they **constrain** lower-level processes

5.4.4 Realism About Higher-Level Entities

Hartmann is a robust realist about higher-level entities.

Hayek is realist about social orders, rules, and institutions.

Both reject eliminativism.

5.5 Differences and Tensions

5.5.1 Systematic vs. Fragmentary Ontology

Hartmann offers a systematic metaphysics; Hayek's ontology is dispersed across psychology and social theory.

5.5.2 Normativity

Hayek's ontology is tied to liberal political theory (rule of law, limits of constructivism).

Hartmann's ontology is descriptive and non-political.

5.5.3 Methodological Divergence

- Hartmann: phenomenological realism, categorial analysis
- Hayek: theory of complex phenomena, epistemic limits, evolutionary accounts

5.6 A Hartmannian Reconstruction of Hayek

5.6.1 Mapping Hayek into Hartmann's Framework

Hartmann's categories can clarify:

- the ontological status of rules
- the nature of social institutions
- the structure of emergent orders

5.6.2 Strengthening Hayek's Anti-Reductionism

Hartmann provides a **metaphysical justification** for Hayek's methodological anti-reductionism.

5.6.3 Implications for Social Ontology

A combined Hartmann–Hayek framework yields:

- a robust realist account of institutions
- a layered model of social reality
- a metaphysics of emergent social order

5.7 Conclusion

Hartmann and Hayek, though intellectually distant, converge on a shared metaphysical vision of **layered reality**, **emergence**, and **irreducibility**.

A systematic comparison reveals that Hartmann’s ontology can deepen and stabilise the metaphysical foundations of Hayek psychological and social theories. In turn Hayek provides detail on the ppsychic and spiritual consequences of an ontology of emergence.

6 Taking process philosophy seriously

6.1 The Philosophical Landscape - physical layer

It was in *Taking Heisenberg's Potentia Seriously* (Kastner et al. 2018) that I first encountered Ruth Kastner's **Relativistic Transactional Interpretation (RTI)**. Michael Epperson, one of the co-authors, has written his own book (Epperson 2004) on quantum mechanics that makes extensive use of the “potentiality” concept. This draws heavily on Whitehead's **Process Philosophy** but does not provide new physics, relying instead on a decoherence narrative used by many others. But this does not work.

Kastner's transactions offer some novel physics in the relativistic formulation, involving an “offer and response” process. In addition, there is an interplay between **space-time events** and the quantum substratum *potentia*. Whitehead's process philosophy (which he misleadingly called a “philosophy of organism”) may possibly provide, or be adapted to provide, a coherent cosmology encompassing quantum processes and events, but the physics of events needs to be formulated as well.

6.2 Alternative Mechanisms

The Relativistic Transactional Interpretation is not the only approach to providing a mechanism for quantum state reduction—leading to events—that is not *ad hoc*. The “**Events, Trees, and Histories**” (ETH) theory, as developed by Jürg Fröhlich and collaborators, also provides a mechanism. As with RTI, their approach requires interaction with massless modes (e.g., photons). However, retro-causality is not invoked.

The key concept in ETH is the “**Principle of Diminishing Potentialities.**” This could be interpreted as adding what is missing from Kochen’s reformulation of QM, but that is not a point that they make. To provide a rounded understanding of a physics that includes potentiality and processes leading to events, a cosmology is needed—an all-encompassing philosophical scheme.

6.3 The Whiteheadian Scheme

An all-encompassing philosophical scheme that includes events and processes at the microscopic, mesoscopic, and macroscopic scales can only be speculative; but speculation should not be arbitrary. Following Whitehead (2010):

“...the philosophical scheme should be coherent, logical, and, in respect to its interpretation, applicable and adequate. Here ‘applicable’ means that some items of experience are thus interpretable, and ‘adequate’ means that there are no items incapable of such interpretation. ‘Coherence,’ as here employed, means that the fundamental ideas, in terms of which the

scheme is developed, presuppose each other so that in isolation they are meaningless... The term ‘logical’ has its ordinary meaning, including ‘logical’ consistency, or lack of contradiction, the definition of constructs in logical terms, the exemplification of general logical notions in specific instances, and the principles of inference.”

6.4 Key Terms in Process and Reality

Technical Term	Explanation	Relevance to Quantum Physics
Actual Entity / Occasion	The fundamental unit of reality; a single, concrete event or experience.	Quantum events or interactions. Each event is a discrete occurrence.
Prehension	The process by which an actual entity “grasps” or is influenced by other entities.	Particles interacting through fundamental forces; influencing one another’s states.
Eternal Object	Abstract entities or pure potentials (similar to Platonic forms) that actual entities can realize.	Properties like position or momentum. Represented by self-adjoint operators, not the wavefunction.

Technical Term	Explanation	Relevance to Quantum Physics
Process	Reality as dynamic “becoming” rather than static “being.”	The flux of particles and fields governed by probabilistic laws.
Creativity	The ultimate principle representing the continuous creation of new actual entities.	Inherent unpredictability and novelty; related to creation operators in QFT.
Singular Causality	Specific, individual causes contributing to a single event.	Specific interactions leading to the collapse of a quantum state.
Nomic Causality	General or universal causes (scientific laws).	General laws like the Heisenberg equation $(i\hbar \frac{d}{dt} A = [A, H])$.
Organism	The interconnected, interdependent nature of reality.	The holistic view of systems where the whole is more than the sum of its parts.
Concrescence	The process of an entity coming into being by integrating many prehensions.	How states evolve and integrate influences to result in a specific event.

Technical Term	Explanation	Relevance to Quantum Physics
Subjective Aim	The inherent goal or purpose an entity strives for in its “becoming.”	Propensity theory; how an outcome is selected from a probability distribution.

6.4.1 Flow diagram of key terms

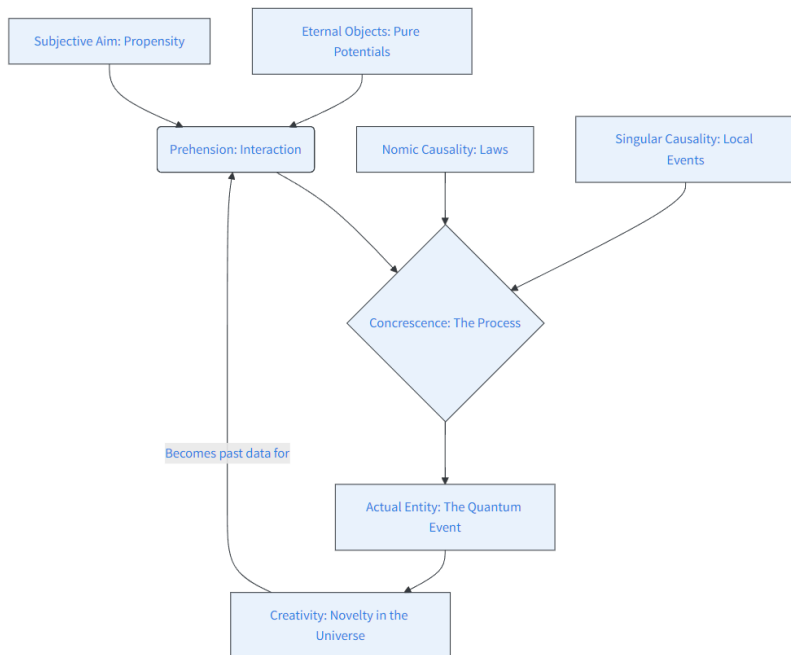


Figure 6.1: Flow diagram of key terms

Part II

Dispositions and powers

1 The ontology of dispositions

1.1 The Ontology of Dispositions and Objective Chance

The motivation for analysing the ontology of dispositions is to understand partial causes and objective chance. It is objective chance that is the stronger interest here, motivated by wanting to understand the behaviour of basic entities at the inorganic ontic level. That is, entities that fall within the remit of quantum physics.

Dispositional properties, as described by Anjum and Mumford (Anjum and Mumford 2018b), will be used to clarify how there can be properties of quantum entities that cause quantifiable property values to appear and influence other objects. This will develop into a dispositional understanding of probabilities in quantum mechanics.

While it is easy to appreciate dispositional properties intuitively, it can be harder to make the concept precise enough to be useful in constructing a scientific theory. To help, the following definitions will be used:

- **Definition 1:** A **disposition** is a property (such as solubility, fragility, elasticity) whose actualisation entails that

the thing which has the property would change, or bring about some change, under certain conditions.

- **Definition 2:** A **dispositional power** is a physically existing dispositional property of an entity.

1.1.1 Intuitive vs. Quantum Dispositions

In everyday use, to say that some object is soluble is to say that it would dissolve if put in some liquid. To say that something is fragile is to say that it would break if, for instance, dropped in suitable circumstances; to say that something is elastic is to say that it would stretch when pulled. The fragility (solubility, elasticity) is a disposition; the breaking (dissolving, stretching) is the actualisation of the disposition.

These examples are intuitively uncontroversial, but position and momentum are not classical dispositional properties of a particle. Results such as that of Kochen and Specker (Kochen and Specker 1967) show that the quantum situation is more subtle than dispositional properties such as solubility and elasticity because they demonstrate a contradiction in assuming that it is possible to assign simultaneously values to all observable properties in all states. Their result, although called a paradox in their paper, indicates the need for an ontology that deals with this more subtle reality.

There is still ongoing debate about the nature of dispositions and key elements of this debate are outlined in Mumford (Mumford 2011). However, the application in physics makes the ontology of causal powers the more attractive interpretation of the nature of dispositions (Anjum and Mumford 2018a). These powers exist and can be independent of an observer.

1.1.2 Popper and Propensity

With the motivation to provide an objective interpretation of chance in quantum mechanics, Popper (Popper 1967), (Popper 1982) took a significant step towards a theory of dispositional properties. He took the position that quantum mechanics is a statistical description of the behaviour of physical entities and introduced dispositional properties through his propensity interpretation of probability:

“...waves (even those of the second quantization) are mathematical representations of propensities, or of dispositional properties, of the physical situation (such as the experimental set-up), interpretable as propensities of the particles to take up certain states.”

Popper proposed that the wave aspect of quantum mechanics determines the tendency of the particles to assume specific states under certain conditions, but with the strength of this disposition given by a probability. However, Popper developed his thinking prior to the demonstration that it is impossible, in general, to assign intrinsic values to all observable properties in all states, and he did not completely develop the ontological consequences. Popper remained committed to a physics in which particles have properties that take values as in classical physics but that the quantum theory provides a statistical description of that reality.

1.1.3 Properties and Fields of Sense

It is proposed here that properties of a physical entity need not all take values simultaneously for them to be physically existing properties. Dispositional properties are properties that govern

how the entity tends to appear in various contexts. For example, a separate physical system may be of the form that couples to an electron's spin in a specific direction and instantiate a value for it. That would be how the electron spin appears to that system.

In the dispositional theory developed in this investigation, there are properties—objective causal powers—and in addition, the probabilistic appearance of the properties as property values. The concepts required to clarify what is meant by “to exist” and “to have a property” are set out in *Why critical ontology?* and *Fields of Sense*.

Dispositional properties cannot themselves appear in a **Field of Sense**, but their effects can. This is the point where the modification of the Field of Sense ontology is used that recognises that there are properties of objects that affect appearances but do not themselves appear. This modification means that Fields of Sense do not provide a complete ontology, contrary to what seems to be proposed by Markus Gabriel (Gabriel 2015).

A dispositional property such as fragility appears if the fragile object breaks—on falling from a table, for example. This is how it appears in a domestic Field of Sense. The fragile object, for example a porcelain cup, exists and appears in the domestic scene even if it does not break. It also has properties that are not dispositional; for example, it has a mass. So, an object can have non-dispositional properties that pin it down in a context. The electron has the properties of charge and (rest) mass that pin it down in the physical universe in which it has (as will be explained elsewhere) dispositional spin, position, and momentum.

1.1.4 Summary of Ontological Position

The position taken on the ontology of dispositions is:

1. Physical objects have at least one property that appears or causes a value to appear in some Field of Sense.
2. Dispositional powers cause property values to appear in Fields of Sense.
3. Physical dispositions are properties of some physical objects.

2 Concepts of causal powers

The concept of dispositions has played a key role in the formulation of objective quantum chance in this blog. However, there is ambiguity about what these are as powers. Ruth Porter Groff (Groff 2021) has helpfully addressed this issue and identified four senses of the term. She identifies dispositional power to be conceptualised as an:

- Activity
- Capacity
- Essence
- Necessitation.

While Groff indicates that there is a further task to work out which is correct in a given context. That is, depending on what is (what the world is like), there could be powers of distinct types. For example, at the various levels of reality (Hartmann) different concepts could play their part. The intention is that clarity on which concept of power applies will strengthen any theory of quantum chance.

These concepts of powers need to be contrasted with what is called the Humean view that there are no necessary connections or causes in nature. That is, there are no powers.

2.1 Activity

Consider a film in which each frame is static. Playing the film gives the impression of movement or activity. If activity in the world is like the film, then activity is an illusion or a metaphor. In which case activity is not an aspect of how things are, and the ontology can be called passive. If activity is not just a sequence of static configurations, then activity may not be an illusion. We can follow Groff and use the term anti-passivist to refer to the opinion that activity is a real and irreducible component of the world.

Activity is taken to cover a range of things. Movement, deliberation (moving away from the visual film example), inquiry and chemical reaction (to take an inorganic example). Any instance of causation is an activity.

The view that there is activity in the world has common sense on its side. For example, action as captured by verbs as part of the deep structure of language.

From this perspective, to say that things in the world have causal powers is to say that things engage in activity and are able to do. Reality is in this sense genuinely, irreducibly, non-metaphorically dynamic. In contrast Esfeld's (Esfeld and Deckert 2017) primitive ontology, that is in favour with some who defend the Bohmian version of Quantum Mechanics, is passive and at best kinematic. It is an example of an extreme (or to use Esfeld's own term Super) Humean ontology.

Real activity contrasts with the Humean view that inanimate matter is essentially passive and never intrinsically active. In real activity the action of things depends on their causal powers. Examples of activity, from Cartwright (2007):

1. The carburettor feeds gasoline and air to a car's engine ...
2. The pistons suck air in through the chamber...
3. The low-pressure air sucks gasoline out of a nozzle ...
4. The throttle valve allows air to flow through the nozzle ...
5. Pressing the pedal opens the throttle valve more, speeding the airflow and sucking in more gasoline...
6. ...

These examples indicate that mechanisms can undertake activity.

2.2 Capacity

A capacity is a way that something presently is, such that it could be a way that it presently is not. The phenomenon of a capacity is thus inherently modal, invoking possibility. That is capacity is the potential to be in a possible state for that thing. This type of potentiality is attached to the nature of a thing and is sometimes called real, or metaphysical possibility, in contrast to logical possibility.

A capacity may be engaged in activity but there is nothing about the concept of a real possibility that requires realism about activity to be either built into it or entailed by it. A power, as a capacity, is a property that need not be fully actualised in the present in order to exist.

Capacities are properties that include, as part of their identity in the present, non-actualized but nevertheless real potential manifestations. By contrast, for the Humean the only properties that exist are categorical properties; properties that are fully occurrent or actual.

2.3 Essence

Essentialism is when things (or some kinds of things) are such that they could not be, in part or in full, otherwise without ceasing to be what they are. Among dispositionalists, Bird Bird (2007) defines powers, or potencies, as fundamental properties whose identities are not just dispositional, but fixed. A power as an essence is to be a property whose identity is essential to it.

2.4 Necessitation

Necessitation is when one thing is the case, some other thing must be the case. A necessary connection is a power in this sense. Equating powers with necessary connections is proposed by Armstrong Armstrong (2005).

It is not clear that even those anti-passivists who are most focused on defending the reality of necessary connections (in the name of defending the notion of a law) do believe in metaphysical necessitation.

What is meant by the term ‘metaphysical necessitation’? To answer this, we need to know

- whether one who affirms it believes
 - that things of a given kind necessarily tend to behave in one way or another, or
 - that they must behave in one way or another; and also
- whether or not one who affirms the existence of metaphysical necessitation holds that given behaviours necessarily bring about assigned outcomes.

Accepting the above would tend someone strongly towards metaphysical determinism and intuitively this would be a natural consequence of necessitation. However, it may be that a version of metaphysical necessity that commits only to the existence of necessary tendencies does not translate into a commitment to what may be called ‘causal necessitarianism,’ or even hard determinism.

2.5 Conclusion

It is conceivable that all the concepts described above have role to play in understanding the role of powers in the world. However, from the posts in this blog on quantum physics and in particular quantum chance it is capacity that seems to be the best fit. This is because the potential to have a physical property is attached to a physical object and possibilities are captured by the set of possible values that can be made actual. For example, an electron has the property of spin with the potential to take certain value. The possible values that can be actualised and with whichever probabilities depends on this potential and the context the particle find itself in.

The concept of activity also has causal force but seems better suited to powers of designed mechanism or psychological or social situations. If a theory can be developed of what gives rise to the occurrence of an actual event in Quantum Mechanics, then activity may be a valid concept for the power in question.

Essence plays a role in quantum chance in that the power that governs the tendency for an object, such as an electron, to take particular values of spin is an essential property of an electron.

That is, an electron would not be an electron if spin and quantum chance were not aspects of its state.

Necessary connections have a role to play in a physical theory even in the presence of objective chance. The evolution of the wavefunction governed by the Schrödinger equation is deterministic making the state of the object necessarily connected to its state at an earlier time.

However, it is proposed that potentiality and possibility are the key concepts, equivalent to capacity, which play the key role in the developing theory of quantum chance. The most complete treatment to date of powers as potentiality and possibility is by Vetter (2015) whose classification of potentiality as a localised modality and possibility as a non-localised modality looks promising. We may then have the quantum state of the electron representing the chance potential to take certain spin values while the possible spin values that can be actualised will depend on the non-localised situation that constrains the quantum state.

Part III

Probability and potentiality

1 Potentiality and Probability

As outlined in the previous chapter, Barbara Vetter (2015) developed the concept of potentiality in her theory of dispositional powers. In that theory, potentials are dispositions that are responsible for the manifestation of possibilities. The possibilities then tend to become actual events or states of affairs. The concept of “potential” in philosophy, in a sense close to that discussed here, goes back at least to Aristotle in *Metaphysics* Book Θ . (Aristotle, n.d.)

In contrast, probabilities are weightings summing to one that describe in what proportion the possibilities tend to appear. I propose that the potential underpins the actual appearance of the possibilities while probability shapes it. This will be discussed further in this chapter.

Barbara Vetter proposed a formal definition of possibility in terms of potentiality:

POSSIBILITY: It is possible that $p =_{def}$ Something has an iterated potentiality for it to be the case that p .

So, it is further proposed that the probabilities are the weights that can be measured through this iteration using the frequency of appearances of each possibility. Note that this indicates how

probabilities can be measured, but it is not a definition of probability.

In the field of disposition research, there is an unfortunate proliferation of terms meaning roughly the same thing. The concept of “power” brings out a disposition’s causal role, but so does “potential.” As technical terms in the field, both are dispositions. Now “tendency” will also be introduced, and it is often used as yet another flavor of disposition.

1.1 Tendencies

Barbara Vetter mentions tendencies in passing in her 2015 book on potentiality and, although she discusses graded dispositions, tendencies are not a major topic in that work. In “What Tends to Be: The Philosophy of Dispositional Modality,” (Anjum and Mumford 2018b) Rani Lill Anjum and Stephen Mumford (2018) provide an examination of the relationship between dispositions and probabilities while developing a substantial theory of dispositional tendency.

In their treatment, powers are understood as disposing towards their manifestations, rather than necessitating them. This is consistent with Vetter’s potentials. Tendencies are powers that do not necessitate manifestations, but nonetheless, the power will iteratively cause the possibility to be the case.

In common usage, a contingency is something that might possibly happen in the future. That is, it is a possibility. A more technical but still common view is that contingency is something that could

be either true or false. This captures an aspect of possibility, but not completely because there is no role for **potentiality**; something responsible for the possibilities. There is also logical possibility in which anything that does not imply a contradiction is logically possible. This concept may be fine for logic, but in this discussion, it is possibilities that can appear in the world that are under consideration. Here, an actual possibility needs a potentiality to tend to produce it.

1.1.1 Example (adapted from Anjum and Mumford)

Struck matches tend to light. Although disposed to light when struck, we all know that there is no guarantee that they will light as there are many times a struck match fails to light. But there is an iterated potentiality for it to be the case that the match lights. The lighting of a struck match is more than a mere possibility or a logical possibility. There are many mere possibilities towards which the struck match has no disposition—that is, no potential in the match towards struck matches melting, for instance.

Iterated potentiality provides the tendency for possible outcomes to show some patterns in their manifestation. In very controlled cases, the number of cases of success in iterations of match striking could provide a measure of the strength of the power that is this potentiality. This would require a collection of matches that are essentially the same.

1.2 Initial Discussion of Probability

Anjum and Mumford introduce their discussion of probability through a simple example that builds on a familiar understanding of dispositional tendencies associated with fragility.

“The fragility of a wine glass, for instance, might be understood to be a strong disposition towards breakage with as much as 0.8 probability, whereas the fragility of a car windscreen predicts its breaking to the lesser degree 0.3. Furthermore, it is open to a holder of such a theory to state that the probability of breakage can increase or decrease in the circumstances and, indeed, that the manifestation of the tendency occurs when and only when its probability reaches one.”

This example is merely an introduction and needs further development, but already the claim that “the manifestation of the tendency occurs when and only when its probability reaches one” shows that it is not a model for objective probability. What is needed is a theory of dispositions that explains stable probability distributions. Of course, if the glass is broken, then the probability of it being broken is 1. However, this has nothing to do with the dispositional tendency to break. What is needed is a systemic understanding of the relationship between the strength of a dispositional tendency and the values or, in the continuous case, shape of a probability distribution.

In the quoted example above, each power is to be understood in terms of a probability of the occurrence of a certain effect, which is given a specific value. The fragility of a wine glass, for instance, might be understood to be a strong disposition towards

breakage with as much as 0.8 probability, whereas the fragility of a car windscreen is less, and the probability of its breaking is a lesser degree 0.3. But given a wine glass or windscreen produced to certain norms and standards, it would be expected that the disposition towards breakage would be quite stable. A glass with a different disposition would be a different glass.

Anjum and Mumford claim that, in some understandings, the manifestation of a possibility occurs when and only when its probability reaches one (see Popper, *A World of Propensities*, (Popper 1990)). This is a misunderstanding of how probability works. Popper distinguished clearly between the mathematical probability measure and what he called the physical propensity, which is more like a force, but Popper does limit a propensity to have a strength of at most 1. As I will attempt to show below, Popper, in proposing the propensity interpretation of objective probabilities, oversimplifies the relationship between dispositions and probabilities. This confusion led Humphreys to draft a paper (Humphreys 1985), *The Philosophical Review*, to show that propensities cannot be probabilities. As indeed they are not. They are dispositions. That would leave open the proposition that probabilities are dispositional tendencies, but that also will turn out to be untenable.

The proposal by Anjum and Mumford that powers can **over-dispose** does seem to be sound. Over-disposing is where there is a stronger magnitude than what is minimally needed to bring about a particular possibility. This indicates that there is a difference between the notion of having a power to some degree and the probability of the power's manifestation occurring. Among other conclusions, this also shows that the dispositional tendency does not reduce to probability, preserving its status as a potential.

Anjum and Mumford continue the discussion using “propen-

sity” as having a tendency to some degree, where degree is non-probabilistically defined. Anjum and Mumford use the notions of “power,” “disposition,” and “tendency” more or less interchangeably, whereas an object may have a power to a degree, there are powers that are simply properties. In what follows, I will try to eliminate the use of “propensity,” except where commenting on the usage of others, and use “tendency” to qualify either “power,” “potential,” or “disposition” rather than let it stand on its own.

1.3 Probability vs. Necessity

A probability always takes a value within a bounded inclusive range between zero and one. If probability is 1, then probability theory stipulates that it is “almost certain” (occurs except for a set of cases of measure zero). In contrast to what Anjum and Mumford claim, it is not natural to interpret this as necessity because there are exceptions. For cases where there are only a finite set of possibilities, then probability 1 does mean that there are no exceptions. But as this is a special case in applied probability theory, there is no justification in equating it with logical or metaphysical necessity.

A power must be strong enough to reach the threshold to make the possibilities actual. Once the power is strong enough, then the probability distribution over the possibilities may be stable or affected by other aspects of the situation. So, instead of understanding powers and their degrees of strength as probabilistic, powers and their tendencies towards certain manifestations are the underpinning grounds of probabilities. Consider the example of tossing a coin.

A coin when tossed has the potential to fall either heads or tails. This tendency to fall either way can be made symmetric and then the coin is “fair.” From which probability weightings of $1/2$ for each outcome (taking account of the tossing mechanism) can be assumed and then confirmed by measuring the proportion of outcomes on iteration. The reason why the head and the tail events are equally probable statistically, when a fair coin is tossed, is that the coin is equally disposed towards those two outcomes due to its physical constitution. The probability weightings derive, in this example, from a symmetry in the potentiality, which in turn derives from the physical composition and detailed geometry of the coin.

1.3.1 The Rai Stone Example



Figure 1.1: https://en.m.wikipedia.org/wiki/Rai_stones

Consider a society that uses very large stone discs as currency (e.g., [Rai stones](#)). On examination of the disc, it would be possible to conjecture that if it were tossed, then there would be two possible outcomes and that those outcomes are equally likely. But this disposition is not realized because of the effort required to construct the tossing mechanism, as such a stone may weigh several metric tons. The enabling disposition that would give rise to the iteration of possibilities would have been this missing tossing mechanism. It is not a property of the disc.

The manifestation of the dispositional tendency of the disc to come to lie in one of two states needs an external mechanism that is disposed through design to toss the coin in a certain way. If the mechanism is constructed, it may be too weak. It may tend to only flip the coin once, giving a sequence such as:

$\dots THTHTHHTHTHTHTHTHTH \dots$

That would give a frequency of T close to 1/2, but the sequence does not exhibit the potential for random outcomes to which the coin is disposed.

1.4 Probabilities and Chance

From the above: potential and possibility are more fundamental than (or prior to) probability. Both are needed to construct and explain objective probability. The alternative, subjective probability, is based on beliefs about possibilities, but that is not the same thing as what is actually possible and how things will appear independently of anyone's beliefs or judgments.

In this investigation, I have already referred to a dispositional tendency beginning to explain objective probabilities in quantum mechanics. The term “propensity” has been used to describe these probabilities. I now think that was wrong. Propensity should be reserved for the dispositional tendency that is responsible for the probabilities to avoid this term merging the underpinning dispositional elements and probability structure. Anjum and Mumford claim that they have made a key contribution to clarifying the relationship between dispositional tendencies and probability through their analysis of **over-disposition**.

Anjum and Mumford claim “information is lost in the putative conversion of propensities to probabilities,” but only if the dispositional grounding of probabilities is forgotten. Their discussion is strongly influenced by their interest in application to medical evidence where a major goal is reduction of uncertainty. Anjum and Mumford propose two rules on how dispositions and probability relate:

1. The more something disposes towards an effect e , the more probable is e , *ceteris paribus*; and the more something over-disposes e , the closer we approach probability $P(e) = 1$.
2. There is a nonlinear “diminishing return” in over-disposing. E.g., if over-disposing e by a magnitude x_2 produces a probability $P(e) = 0.98$, over-disposing x_3 might increase that probability “only” to $P(e) = 0.99$, and over-disposing x_4 “only” to $P(e) = 0.995$, and so on.

While these rules are fine as propositions, they miss the mark in explaining the relationship between dispositions and probability. In the coin tossing example, strengthening the mechanism is not about strengthening one outcome. Over-disposing does provide support for the distinction between the strength of the disposition and value of the probability, but the relationship between underpinning potentials, dispositional mechanisms, and the iterated outcomes needs to be made clear.

1.5 Radioactive Decay and Quantum Theory

Anjum and Mumford also discuss coin tossing and make substantially the same points as I made above. However, having clarified

the distinction between propensity and probability, they revert to using the term propensity in a way that risks confusing the concepts of dispositional tendency and probabilities with random outcomes. They say “50% propensity” rather than “50% probability.” They then introduce the term “chance” that they relate to outcomes in some specified situations. Propensity is then reserved by them for potential probability while chance is the probability of an outcome in a situation. This is more confusing than helpful.

Anjum and Mumford go on to a discussion of radioactive decay that is known to be described by quantum theory. They make no mention of quantum theory (this will be corrected by them in Chapter 4) and strangely claim that radioactive decay is not probabilistic. The probability distributions derived from quantum mechanics unambiguously give the probability of decay per unit time. There are, per unit time, two possibilities: “decay” or “no decay.” Their error is to claim “only one manifestation type” (decay) and from this that there is only one possibility. Ignoring quantum mechanics, they write:

“The reason it is tempting to think of radioactive decay as probabilistic is that there is certainly a distinct tendency to decay that varies in strength for different kinds of particles, where that strength is specified in terms of a half-life (the time at which there is a 50/50 chance of decay having occurred).”

But no, the reason to think that radioactive decay is probabilistic is that our best theory of nuclear phenomena explains it in terms of probabilities. This misunderstanding leads them to introduce the concept of indeterministic propensities. Independently of how they arrived at the concept, it is left open as to whether there

are non-probabilistic indeterminate powers, but radioactive decay is not an example.

1.6 Conclusion

The examples of the concept of chance provided by Anjum and Mumford can be derived in their examples from a correct application of probability theory. Chance is often used as a term for “objective probability,” and I have done so in previous chapters. I will continue to follow that usage and exploit the clarification obtained from the analysis above shows that objective probability depends on the possibilities that are properties of an object. The manifestation of these possibilities may require an enabling mechanism. The statistical regularities displayed by these manifestations on iteration are due primarily to the physical properties of the object unless the enabling mechanism is badly designed.

The term “propensity” has given rise to much confusion in the literature. Now that we are reaching an explanation of objective probability, the term “propensity” might better be avoided.

I propose that the model of objective probability is that:

OBJECTIVE PROBABILITY: An object has probabilistic properties if it is physically constituted so that it has a potential to manifest possibilities that show statistical regularities.

It is possible to describe statistical regularities without invoking the term “probability.” Although some criticism of Anjum and Mumford is implied here, I recognize that their contribution has

done much to disentangle considerations about the strength of dispositions that describe tendencies from a direct interpretation as probabilities. However, the value of the three distinctions they have identified is mixed:

1. **Chance and probability** are not fundamentally distinct and just require a correct application of probability theory.
2. **Probabilistic dispositional tendencies** are distinct from non-probabilistic dispositional tendencies: this is a real and fruitful distinction.
3. **Deterministic and indeterministic dispositional tendencies** also provide a useful distinction, but it remains to be seen whether there are fundamental non-probabilistic indeterministic dispositions.

2 The Kolmogorov probability axioms and objective chance

Philosophy of Probability and Statistical Modelling by Mauricio Suárez (Suárez 2021) provides a historical overview of the philosophy of probability and argues for the significance of this philosophy for well-founded statistical modelling. Within this wider scope, the book discusses the themes: objective probability, propensities, and measurements. So, it has much in common with the themes of this investigation.

Suárez defends a model of objective probability that disentangles propensity from single-case chance and the observed sequences of outputs that result in relative frequencies of outcomes. This is close to what I argued for in *Potentiality and Probability*, but there are differences that I will return to in a future chapter.

2.1 Subjective vs. Objective Probability

Suárez's main theme is objective probability, but he expends a lot of effort on examining subjective probabilities. I have no doubt that subjective probability has its place alongside objective probability but an *ad hoc* mixture of the two is to be avoided.

Subjective probability has been zealously defended by de Finetti and Jaynes to the point of them attempting to eliminate objective

probability altogether. I believe, however, the chapters of this investigation make a case for objective probability as an aspect of ontology. In this chapter I will focus on the Kolmogorov axioms of probability. Curiously, it is only in examining subjective probability that Suárez discusses the axioms of probability.

2.2 The Suárez Formulation

The axioms that Suárez states are as follows. Let $\{E_1, E_2, \dots, E_n\}$ be the set of events over which an agent's degrees of belief range; and let Ω be an event which occurs necessarily. The axioms of probability may be expressed as follows:

Axiom 1: $0 \leq P(E) \leq 1$, for any E : In other words, all probabilities lie in the real unit number interval.

Axiom 2: $P(\Omega) = 1$: The tautologous proposition, or the necessary event has probability one.

Axiom 3: If $\{E_1, E_2, \dots, E_n\}$ are exhaustive and exclusive events, then $P(E_1) + P(E_2) + \dots + P(E_n) = P(\Omega) = 1$: This is known as the addition law and is sometimes expressed equivalently as follows: If $\{E_1, E_2, \dots, E_n\}$ is a set of exclusive (but not necessarily exhaustive) events then: $P(E_1 \vee E_2 \vee \dots \vee E_n) = P(E_1) + P(E_2) + \dots + P(E_n)$.

Axiom 4: $P(E_1 \wedge E_2) = P(E_1|E_2)P(E_2)$. This is sometimes known as the multiplication axiom, the axiom of conditional probability, or the ratio analysis of conditional probability since it expresses the conditional probability of E_1 given E_2 .

According to Suárez, the Kolmogorov axioms are essentially equivalent to those above.

2.3 The Kolmogorov Formulation

Nathan Morrison has translated the Kolmogorov axioms (Kolmogorov 2018) as:

Let E be a collection of elements $\xi, \eta, \zeta, \dots$, which we shall call elementary events, and $\mathfrak{F}$ a set of subsets of E ; the elements of the set $\mathfrak{F}$ will be called random events.

I. $\mathfrak{F}$ is a field of sets.

II. $\mathfrak{F}$ contains the set E .

III. To each set A in $\mathfrak{F}$ is assigned a non-negative real number $P(A)$. This number $P(A)$ is called the probability of the event A .

IV. $P(E)$ equals 1.

V. If A and B have no element in common, then $P(A \cup B) = P(A) + P(B)$.

Terminology has moved on and it would now be usual to identify the triple $(E, \mathfrak{F}, P)$ as the probability space with the term field reserved for the Borel field of sets $\mathfrak{F}$. In addition, it is preferable not to use the same symbol for the addition of numbers and the union of sets.

It is also important to note that $\xi, \eta, \zeta, \dots$, indicating the elements of E does not constrain the set of elementary events to be a countable set. This is important for applications to statistical

and quantum physics where, for example, particle positions and momentum can take a continuum of values.

It is a shorthand when Kolmogorov writes in Axiom III that the number $P(A)$ is the probability of the event A . The full interpretation is that $P(A)$ is the probability that the outcome will be an element in A . In the same Axiom III, the use of the term “assigned” is also deceptive. The probabilities are more properly assigned to the singleton set with each element of E as the sole member and from that the probability for each set in $\mathfrak{F}$ is constructed.

2.3.1 Mapping Logic to Set Theory

As Suárez is dealing with probabilities as credences (degrees of belief) in this section of his book, it would have been better to consistently employ the language and symbols of propositional logic. To maintain consistency, especially when dealing with credences, we can map the language of propositional logic to set theory:

Logical Category	Set Theoretical Category	Symbol Mapping
Elementary propositions	Elementary events	$\xi, \eta, \dots$
Logical ‘And’	Set Intersection	$\wedge \rightarrow \cap$
Logical ‘Or’	Set Union	$\vee \rightarrow \cup$
Tautology	Universal Set	$\Omega \rightarrow E$

2.4 A Reformulated Neutral Axiom Set

I propose that this is a neutral set of axioms for a probability theory. It has one advantage that it can be applied to eventless situations such as in the quantum description of a free particle.

Let E be a collection of elements $\xi, \eta, \zeta, \dots$, which we shall call **elementary possibilities** and $\mathfrak{F}$ a set of subsets of E .

I. $\mathfrak{F}$ is a field of sets.

II. $\mathfrak{F}$ contains the set E .

III. To each set A in $\mathfrak{F}$ is assigned a non-negative real number $P(A)$. This number $P(A)$ is called the probability of A , an element of $\mathfrak{F}$.

IV. $P(E)$ equals 1.

V. If A and B in $\mathfrak{F}$ have no element in common, then $P(A \cup B) = P(A) + P(B)$.

VI. For any A and B in $\mathfrak{F}$, $P(A|B) = \frac{P(A \cap B)}{P(B)}$ is the conditional probability.

Such a system of sets $\mathfrak{F}, E$, together with a definite assignment of numbers $P(A)$ for all $A \in \mathfrak{F}$, satisfying Axioms I-V, is called a **probability space**.

2.5 Applications: The Die and the Electron

In adopting these axioms for objective chance, the collection of elements can again be called elementary events or possible events, and P is a numerical assignment furnished by a theory or estimated through experiment.

The Die Example: A simple physical example is provided by a die with six sides. These six possibilities are the elementary events E . These outcomes are not in $\mathfrak{F}$, the set of subsets of E that Kolmogorov calls events. For example, the outcome “face 5 faces upwards” is not in the set of random events but the subset {“face 5 faces upwards”} is.

$P(\{\text{face 5 faces upwards}\})$ can be estimated as the proportion of times it occurs in a long run of repetitions. I emphasize that this is not a relative frequency interpretation; here the relative frequencies are an estimate of the numerical probability assignment. $P(\{\text{face 5 faces upwards}\})$ itself is the relative strength of the tendency for that event to occur, otherwise known as the **single-case chance**.

The Quantum Example: An example is the case of an observation of an electron governed by the Schrödinger equation. According to quantum mechanics the probability of it being observed at any pre-designated spot is zero. In this example, all the elements of the set of elementary events have numerical probability assignment zero. This is where the field of events $\mathfrak{F}$ is useful in providing sets with non-zero probability in which the position of the electron may be observed.

2.6 Conclusion

The subjectivity enters through interpreting P as credence or degree of belief. In applications with objective probability, $P(A)$ is a numerical assignment of the strength of the single-chance tendency for an elementary event to appear in set A . In objective probability P is **ontological**, but in subjective probability it is **epistemic**.

3 Conditional probability: Renyi versus Kolmogorov

Four years ago, I wrote about Renyi's axiomatisation of probability that, in contrast to that of Kolmogorov, takes conditional probability as the fundamental concept. It is timely to revisit the topic given my last chapter on Kolmogorov's axioms. In addition, Suarez (whose latest book was also discussed in a previous chapter (Suárez 2021)) appears to endorse the Renyi axioms (Rényi 1969) over those of Kolmogorov (Kolmogorov 2018) although only in a footnote. Stephen Mumford, Rani Lill Anjum and Johan Arnt Myrstad in the book *What Tends to Be*, Chapter 6 (Anjum and Mumford 2018b) also follow their analysis of conditional probability in the Kolmogorov axiomatisation by taking the view that conditional probabilities should not be reducible to absolute probabilities.

In his *Foundations of Probability* (1969) Renyi provided an alternative axiomatisation to that of Kolmogorov that takes conditional probability as the fundamental notion, otherwise he stays as close as possible to Kolmogorov. As with the Kolmogorov axioms, I shall replace reference to events with possibilities.

Renyi's conditional probability space $(\Omega, \mathfrak{F}(\mathfrak{G}), P(F|G))$ is defined as follows.

The set Ω is the space of elementary possibilities and $\mathfrak{F}$ is a σ -field of subsets of Ω and $\mathfrak{G}$, a subset of $\mathfrak{F}$ (called the set of admissible conditions) having the properties):

- (a) $G_1, G_2 \in \mathfrak{G} \Rightarrow G_1 \cup G_2 \in \mathfrak{G}$,
- (b) $\exists \{G_n\}$, a sequence in $\mathfrak{G}$, such that $\cup_{n=1}^{\infty} G_n = \Omega$,
- (c) $\emptyset \notin \mathfrak{G}$,

P is the conditional probability function satisfying the following four axioms:

- R0. $P : \mathfrak{F} \times \mathfrak{G} \rightarrow [0, 1]$,
- R1. $\forall G \in \mathfrak{G}, P(G|G) = 1$
- R2. $\forall G \in \mathfrak{G}, P(\cdot|G)$, is a countably additive measure on $\mathfrak{F}$.
- R3. If $\forall G_1, G_2 \in \mathfrak{G}, G_2 \subseteq G_1 \Rightarrow P(G_2|G_1) > 0$,

$$(\forall F \in \mathfrak{F}) P(F|G_2) = \frac{P(F \cap G_2|G_1)}{P(G_2|G_1)}.$$

Several problems have been examined by Stephen Mumford, Rani Lill Anjum and Johan Arnt Myrstad in *What Tends to Be*, Chapter 6, as part of a critique of the applicability of Kolmogorov's definition of conditional probability to the ontology of dispositions that tend to cause or hinder events. These have been analysed by them using Kolmogorov's absolute probabilities, but without a careful construction of the probability space appropriate for the application. These same examples will be analysed here using both Kolmogorov's and Renyi's formulation.

The first example that indicates a problem with absolute probability (absolute probability will be denoted by μ below to avoid

confusion with Renyi's function P , the σ -field, $\mathfrak{F}$ is the same for both).

P1. For $A, B \in \mathfrak{F}$, let $\mu(A) = 1$ then $\mu(A|B) = 1$, μ is Kolmogorov's absolute probability.

Strictly this holds only for sets with measure greater than one. We can calculate this result from Kolmogorov's conditional probability as follows:

$$\mu(A \cap B) = \mu(B),$$

$$\mu(A|B) = \mu(A \cap B)/\mu(B) = \mu(B)/\mu(B) = 1.$$

This is not problematic within the mathematics but Mumford et al consider it to be if $\mu(A|B)$ is to be understood as a degree of implication. They claim that there must exist a condition under which the probability of A decreases. They justify this through an example: Say we strike a match and it lights. The match is lit and thus the (unconditional) probability of it being lit is one. Still, this does not entail that the match lit given that there was a strong wind. A number of conditions could counteract the match lighting, thus lowering the probability of this outcome. The match might be struck in water, the flammable tip could have been knocked off, the match could have been sucked into a black hole, and so on. Let us analyse this more closely. Let A = "the match lights". Then, "The match is lit and thus the (unconditional) probability of it being lit is one." is equivalent to $\mu(A|A) = 1$. This is not controversial. They go on to bring other considerations into play and, intuitively, it seems evident that whether a match is lit or not will depend on the existing situation. For example, on whether it is wet or dry, windy, or not,

and whether the match is stuck effectively. But this enlarges the space the elementary possibilities. In this enlarged probability space, the set A labelled “the match lights” is

$$A = \{(\text{“the match is lit”}, \text{“it is windy”}, \text{“it is dry”}, \text{“match is struck”}) \cup \\ \{(\text{“the match is lit”}, \text{“it is not windy”}, \text{“it is dry”}, \text{“match is struck”}) \cup \\ \{(\text{“the match is lit”}, \text{“it is windy”}, \text{“it is not dry”}, \text{“match is struck”}) \dots\dots$$

where indicates all the other subsets (elementary possibilities) that make up A .

Each elementary possibility is now a 4-tuple and A is the union of all sets consisting of a single 4-tuple in which the first item is “the match is lit”. Similarly, a set can be constructed to represent $B =$ “match stuck”. The probability function over the probability space is constructed from the probabilities assigned to each elementary possibility. An assignment can be made such that

$$\mu(A|B) = 1 \text{ or } \mu(A|B^C) = 0$$

where B^C (“match not struck”) is the complement of B . It would not be a physically or causally feasible allocation of probabilities to have $\mu(A|B^C) = 1$ whereas $\mu(A|B) = 0$ is. Indeed, a physically valid allocation of probabilities should give $\mu(A \cap B^C) = \mu(\emptyset) = 0$. All Kolmogorov probability assignments of elementary possibilities with “the match is lit” and “match not struck” in the 4-tuples of elementary possibilities should be zero. The Kolmogorov ratio formula for the conditional probability would apply in the case when all the conditions are accommodated in the set of elementary possibilities. Therefore, P1 is not a problem for

the Kolmogorov axioms if the probability space is appropriately modelled.

Appropriate modelling is just as relevant when using the Renyi axioms. In addition, as we are working in the context of conditions influencing outcomes, we will not allow outcomes that cannot be influenced to be in the set of admissible conditions $\mathfrak{G}$. This has no effect on the analysis of P1 but, as will be discussed below, is important for modelling causal conditions.

A further problematic consequence of Kolmogorov's conditional probability, according to Mumford et al, is when A and B are probabilistically independent P2. $\mu(A \cap B) = \mu(A)\mu(B)$ implies $\mu(A|B) = \mu(A)$. This is indeed a consequence of Kolmogorov's definition. Renyi's formulation does not allow this analysis to be carried out, unless $\mathfrak{G} = \mathfrak{F}$. Mumford et al illustrate their concern through an example. The dispositional properties of solubility and sweetness are not generally thought to be probabilistically dependent. Whatever is generally thought, the mathematical analysis will depend on the probability model. If two properties are probabilistically independent, then that should be captured in the model. However the objections of Mumford et al are combined with a criticism of Adam's Thesis Assert (if B then A) = $P(\text{if B then A}) = P(A \text{ given } B) = P(A|B)$ where $P(A|B)$ is given by the Kolmogorov ratio formula. However, it should be remembered that the Kolmogorov ratio formula can be simply showing correlation and not that B causes A or that B implies A to any degree. I do not want to get into defending or challenging this thesis here but within the Renyi axiomatisation the Kolmogorov conditional probability formula only holds under special conditions, see R3. Independence, in Renyi's scheme, is only defined with reference to some conditioning set, C say. In which case probabilistic independence is described by the condition

$$P(A \cap B|C) = P(A|C)P(B|C)$$

and as a consequence, it is only if $B \subseteq C$ that

$$P(A|B) = \frac{P(A \cap B|C)}{P(B|C)} = P(A|C)$$

This means that if a set D in $\mathfrak{G}$ that is not a subset of C is used to condition $A \cap B$ then, in general,

$$P(A \cap B|D) \neq P(A|D)P(B|D)$$

even if

$$P(A \cap B|C) = P(A|C)P(B|C).$$

This shows that in the Renyi axiomatisation statistical independence is not an absolute property of two sets.

The third objection is that regardless of the probabilistic relation between A and B , a third consequence of the Kolmogorov conditional probability definition is that whenever the probability of A and B is high $\mu(A|B)$ is high and so is $\mu(B|A)$: P3. $(\mu(A \cap B) \sim 1) \Rightarrow ((\mu(A|B) \sim 1) \wedge \mu(B|A) \sim 1)$. If $\mu(A \cap B) \sim 1$ then $A \equiv B$ but for a set of measure zero. Then $\mu(A) \sim 1$ and $\mu(B) \sim 1$ that implies the statement in P3. Mumford et al object The probability of the conjunction of ‘the sun will rise tomorrow’ and ‘snow is white’ is high. But this doesn’t necessarily imply that the sun rising tomorrow is conditional upon snow being white, or vice versa. That may be the case but the correlation between situations where both are the case is high. Once again, the problem is the identification of conditional probability with a degree of implication in Adam’s Thesis. But it is well known that conditional probability may simply capture correlation. If we

want to separate conditioning sets from other sets that are consequences in the σ -algebra generated by all elementary possibilities, then Renyi's axioms allow this.

The Renyi equivalent of P3 is

$$P(A \cap B|C) \sim 1 \Rightarrow (P(A|B) \sim 1, B \subseteq C) \wedge (P(B|A) \sim 1, A \subseteq C)$$

It does hold, when both A and B are subsets of C but that is then a reasonable conclusion for the case of both A and B included in C . However, if one of the sets is not a subset of C then it will not hold in general.

When $\mathfrak{G}$ is a smaller set than $\mathfrak{F}$ it becomes useful for causal conditioning. We can exclude sets from $\mathfrak{G}$ that are outcomes and include sets that are causes. If we are interested in causes of snow be white, we will condition in facts of crystallography and local conditions that may turn snow yellow, as pointed out by Frank Zappa.

For the earlier example above the set A , "the match lights" would not be included in $\mathfrak{G}$. So for $C \in \mathfrak{G}$, $P(A|C)$ is a defined probability measure but $P(C|A)$ is not.

The Kolmogorov axioms are good for modelling situations where measurable sets represent events of the same status. If there are reasons to believe that some sets have the status of causal conditions for other sets then they should be modelled with Renyi's axiomatisation (or some similar axiomatisation) as subsets of the set of admissible conditions.

The next question is whether adopting, and modelling fully, with the Renyi scheme allows a counter to objections such as those of Humphreys (1985) to using conditional probabilities to represent dispositional probabilities.

Part IV

Physical layer

1 A Relational Reconstruction of Quantum Mechanics

The mathematical formulation to be discussed here is a modification of Kochen's Reconstruction of Quantum Mechanics (Kochen 2015). It concentrates on a mathematical formulation using a union of σ -algebras that he calls a **complex**. In Kochen's reformulation, it is through the interaction of a quantum system under consideration with another system that properties gain physical values. Such properties are said by Kochen to be **relational** or **extrinsic**, as opposed to fixed intrinsic properties such as the charge of an electron.

While the mathematics depends heavily on the reconstruction by Kochen, it makes use of **von Neumann *-algebras** (see Thirring (Thirring 1979)) rather than the Boolean algebras used by Kochen. This choice is made to avoid any hint of a logical interpretation and will be useful when we move on to discussing relativistic quantum mechanics and field theory. This formulation also differs from Kochen's in the treatment and assignment of both intrinsic and extrinsic properties. The extrinsic properties will be treated here as an actualization of potential, [dispositional properties](#) of the quantum entity that are shaped by its context.

In the mathematical formulation of quantum mechanics, a physical system, **S**, is characterized by a list of properties (called

observables in standard quantum mechanics) that can be represented by abstract self-adjoint operators:

$$\mathcal{O}_{\mathbf{S}} = \{\hat{X}_i = \hat{X}_i^* \mid i \in \mathcal{I}_{\mathbf{S}}\},$$

with $\mathcal{I}_{\mathbf{S}}$ a set of indices depending on $\mathbf{S}$, where every operator $\hat{X} \in \mathcal{O}_{\mathbf{S}}$ represents a physical property characteristic of $\mathbf{S}$, such as the total momentum, energy, or spin of all particles localized in some bounded region of physical space and belonging to an ensemble of (possibly infinitely many) particles constituting the system $\mathbf{S}$.

At every time t , there is a representation of $\mathcal{O}_{\mathbf{S}}$ by self-adjoint operators acting on a separable Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}_{\mathbf{S}}$:

$$\mathcal{O}_{\mathbf{S}} \ni \hat{X}_i \mapsto X_i = X_i^* \in \mathcal{A}(\mathcal{H}_{\mathbf{S}}),$$

where $\mathcal{A}(\mathcal{H}_{\mathbf{S}})$ is the $*$ -algebra of all bounded operators acting on $\mathcal{H}_{\mathbf{S}}$.

In general, the operators in the $*$ -algebra do not all commute. This has deep physical consequences:

- Properties that cannot appear together are represented in quantum mechanics by self-adjoint operators that do not all commute.
- The sets of operators that do commute provide a set of properties for a measurable mathematical structure which is a **σ -algebra**.

The σ -algebra is essential to constructing mathematical probability models using the Kolmogorov axiomization (Kolmogorov 2018). Therefore, each collection of commuting observables of the

object has an associated σ -algebra. So, a collection of σ -algebras that together capture all the property values associated with the object covers all possible events for that object in itself. This structure is the minimal one which contains all the σ -algebras arising from all the properties of the particle.

Each dispositional property of an object, such as spin or position, has a σ – *algebra* of possible values that appear in interaction with other objects. All these σ -algebras form a complex property structure for the object under consideration. The formal definition of this notion is as follows:

Definition: Let F be a family of σ -algebras. The σ -complex Q_F based on F is the union, $\cup B$, of all σ -algebras B lying in F :

$$Q_F = \bigcup_{B \in F} B.$$

Generally, the family F is left implicit, and reference is simply made to a σ -complex Q ; however, the family F does tie the complex to an object that has properties that take values depending on the set of possible interactions that it can have with other objects. Usually, σ -complexes that are closed under the formation of sub- σ -algebras are discussed. It is possible, in any case, to always close a σ -complex by adding all its sub- σ -algebras. This complex will include all the possible values that the dispositional properties of a particle can take in all possible interaction contexts. B denotes the σ -algebra relating to the property values of a particular (commuting) set of observables of the particle or system.

In the mathematical formulation of quantum mechanics, $\mathcal{H}$ is a Hilbert space. For the quantum object under consideration, all

properties are represented by self-adjoint operators and possible events are represented by projection operators. For pairwise commuting projection operators, closure under the operation of orthogonal complement and countable product $\prod_i \pi_i$ forms a σ -algebra. The family of all such σ -algebras forms a σ -complex, $Q(\mathcal{H})$, for the object in its possible interaction contexts.

1.0.1 Proposition

In quantum mechanics, the operators representing the possible values of the properties of a system form the σ -complex $Q(\mathcal{H})$ of projections of the Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}$ of the system.

It has been shown (Kochen 2015) that this proposition holds and the mathematical formalism using $Q(\mathcal{H})$ is equivalent to the standard quantum formulation of the theory on $\mathcal{H}$. However, the interpretation of the formalism here is that while a quantum object has a complete set of properties, they appear only when the situation invokes the σ -algebra in the complex that allows that property to take a specific set of values.

2 Heisenberg, Potentiality, and Quantum Ontology

Heisenberg, in one of his excursions into philosophy, *Physics and Philosophy*, (Heisenberg 1958), discusses epistemology, logic, and ontology. In developing his ideas on how the innovations of quantum mechanics impact philosophy, he introduces (or rather reintroduces, with reference to Aristotle) the concepts of **potentiality**.

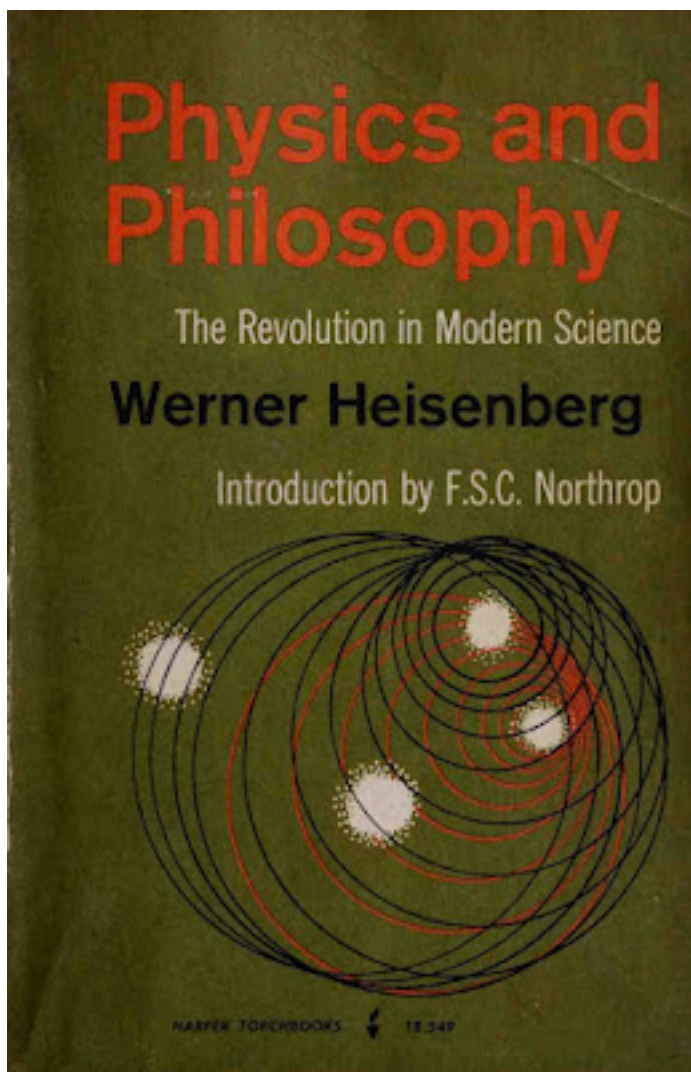


Figure 2.1: Physics and Philosophy

He comes to potentiality through considering the logic required to refer to things that quantum mechanics describes. That is, it ...

“... concerns the ontology that underlies the modified logical patterns. If the pair of complex numbers represents a ‘statement’ in the sense just described, there should exist a ‘state’ or a ‘situation’ in nature in which the statement is correct. We will use the word ‘state’ in this connection. The ‘states’ corresponding to complementary statements are then called ‘coexistent states’ by Weizsäcker. This term ‘coexistent’ describes the situation correctly; it would in fact be difficult to call them ‘different states,’ since every state contains to some extent also the other ‘coexistent states.’ This concept of ‘state’ would then form a first definition concerning the ontology of quantum theory. One sees at once that this use of the word ‘state,’ especially the term ‘coexistent state,’ is so different from the usual materialistic ontology that one may doubt whether one is using a convenient terminology. On the other hand, if one considers the word ‘state’ as describing some potentiality rather than a reality—one may even simply replace the term ‘state’ by the term ‘potentiality’—then the concept of ‘coexistent potentialities’ is quite plausible, since one potentiality may involve or overlap other potentialities.”

In the version of quantum mechanics that I have been developing, these *coexistent potentialities* should be understood in relation to the σ -complex. Despite his hints, Heisenberg does not succeed in including potentiality in the required logic. What is needed is a **modal logic** that includes a **POTENTIALITY operator**.

Barbara Vetter constructs such a modal logic and defends it with modal metaphysical arguments in her book *Potentiality: From Dispositions to Modality* (Vetter 2015).

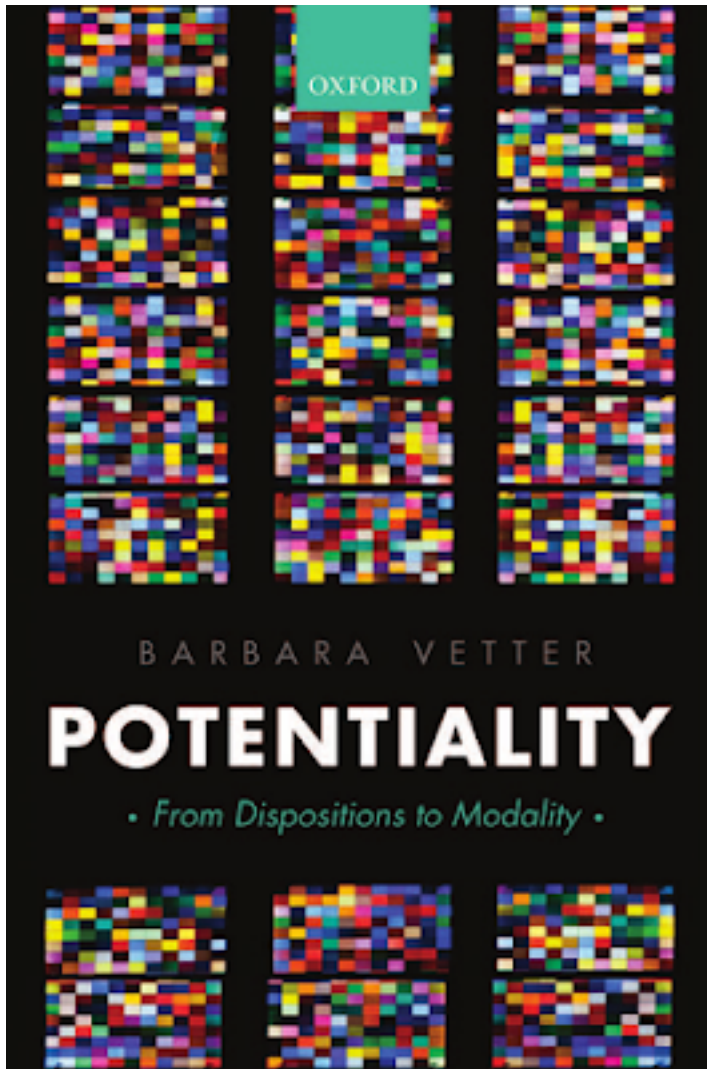


Figure 2.2: Potentiality: From Dispositions to Modality

There is a need for a theory going beyond the naïve position that there are objects that simply have the potential to have certain properties. In quantum mechanics in particular it is not sufficient to say that an electron has the potential to be in some place. If this is elaborated to saying that it has some position with a certain probability, we get a deceptive oversimplification. The theory of potentiality developed by Vetter gives potentialities the status of **properties of objects**. Contrary to Heisenberg’s view that “one considers the word ‘state’ as describing some potentiality rather than a reality,” Vetter’s theory allows us to enlarge the domain of what is real to include potentialities.

2.1 Possibility and Iterated Potentiality

In standard quantum mechanics, observables can take possible values. The possibility is described by the theory, and the values are represented by the spectrum of the self-adjoint operator that represents the observable.

Vetter proposes, in general, to define possibility as follows:

POSSIBILITY:

It is possible that $p =_{\text{df}}$ Something has an iterated potentiality for it to be the case that p .

We have now moved on to potentiality and, more generally, its **iteration**. I have discussed dispositions in previous posts and now explore Vetter’s proposal that we call those properties which form the metaphysical background for disposition ascriptions **potentialities**. In the definition, the *something* also needs explanation. Something can be an object or any collection of objects.

Potentialities are individuated not by a pair of stimulus and manifestation and a corresponding conditional, but by their **manifestation alone**. The manifestation of a potentiality is the property that the potentiality's possessor would have if the potentiality were to be manifested. A manifestation can be a property of an object (or collection of objects) or a relation that the object (or collection) has with something else.

2.2 Joint Potentiality

The relation between a potentiality and its manifestation—the relation “... is a potentiality to ...”—allows a classification of joint potentialities:

- **Type 1 joint potentialities:** the manifestation is a relation between, or a plural property of, *all* its possessors.
- **Type 2 joint potentialities:** the manifestation consists in a property or relation of *only some*, but not all, of its possessors.

Examples of Type 1 include the door key's joint potentiality with the door for the former to unlock the latter.

Examples of Type 2 include:

- a uranium pile (with a potential to go unstable) plus the rods and fail-safe mechanism
- a glass (with a potential to break) but protected by styrofoam
- a city (with a potential to be destroyed) and its defence system

In all three, only one of the objects manifests the disposition or potentiality, but they jointly have the potentiality to a certain degree.

2.3 Extrinsic Potentiality

An object has an **extrinsic potentiality** if it has a joint potentiality whose co-possessors are the *dependees* of the extrinsic potentiality. In the key–door example, the door is part of the manifestation (unlocking the door). In general, where a potentiality’s manifestation consists in a relation to a particular other object—such as opening *this* particular door—the potentiality will be extrinsic.

2.4 Iterated Potentiality

Potentialities themselves are properties. So objects can have:

- potentialities to have potentialities
- potentialities to have potentialities to have potentialities
- and so on, indefinitely.

These are **iterated potentialities**.

2.5 Formalising Potentiality

In Vetter's theory, potentialities include dispositions and abilities as properties of individual objects or collections of objects. POTENTIALITY cannot be defined, because it is metaphysically fundamental, but it can be **formalised**.

Just as modal operators act on propositions, the modal potentiality operator is:

POT

POT is a **predicate-forming operator**. Where Φ is a predicate:

$\text{POT}[\Phi](t)$

ascribes to t the potentiality to Φ .

To allow POT to operate on sentences, we introduce the λ -operator:

$\text{POT}[\Phi](t) \rightarrow \text{POT}[\lambda x. \phi](t)$

where $\lambda x. \phi$ means "is such that ϕ ".

A simple iterated potentiality is:

$\text{POT}[\lambda x. \text{POT}[F](x)](a)$

which ascribes to a the potentiality to have the potentiality to be F .

2.6 The Electron

The electron, as described by quantum mechanics, demonstrates the ontological strangeness of quantum objects:

- it has the potential to be somewhere
- to have a momentum
- to have charge and mass

But quantum mechanics gives more structure: the electron appears somewhere with a **probability**, and these probability models are combined in a **σ -complex**, corresponding (possibly) to Weizsäcker's "coexistent states".

The electron has a **joint potentiality** with other objects to manifest one of the probability distributions from the complex. That probability distribution weights the appearance of specific values of the property with a numerical probability.

In an experiment the electron does not appear directly but only through observable effects on the objects with which it is in a relationship. The electron never appears in the way that a macroscopic object (such as a book) appears, with phonomonological directness. The electron is never in space-time but it does influence other objects that are in space-time to show the effects of its presence as a potentiality.

Thus:

- the probability that the electron appears in a region of space
- in certain circumstances **and** on in relation to other objects.

is itself an **iterated potentiality**.

This example indicates how the concept of potentiality, as formalised, can be used to describe quantum processes. It remains to be seen how useful this will be when we introduce considerations of spin, entanglement, interference, etc. This will be explored in further chapters.

3 The double slit experiment

Having discussed the issues with quantum measurement in general, and shown that standard interpretation of quantum mechanics is incomplete, Young's double slit experiment with electrons will be discussed in two variants (for background see Chapter 1 of Hall (2013)): The standard configuration, to be described below, Figure (1). A configuration with a pointer that acts behind the slits to point in the direction of the passing electron, Figure (2).

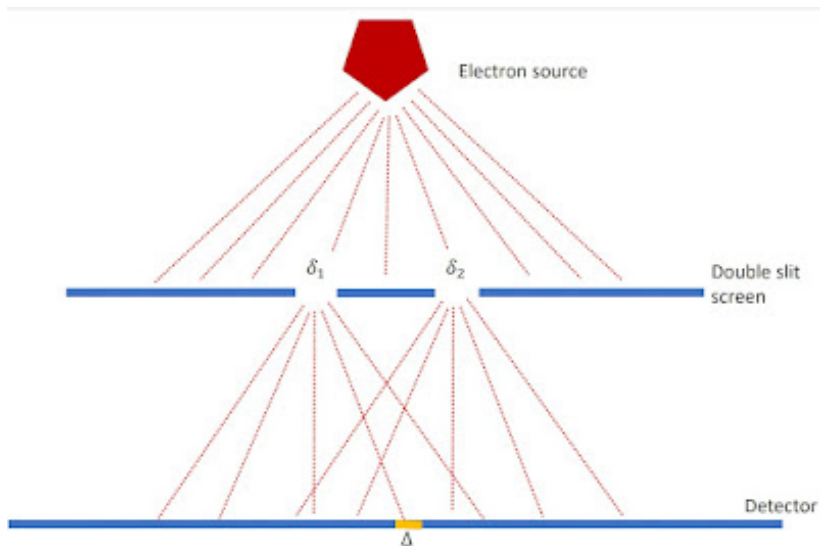


Figure 3.1: Figure (1) The setup for the double slit experiment is shown. An electron source sends one particle at a time toward the screen with the slits. The slits are marked by δ_1 and δ_2 and a sample region Δ is shown on the detector screen.

3.1 Standard configuration

The experiment, Figure (1), is as follows:

There is a source of electrons that move towards a screen with two slits.

The intensity of the beam is low and only one electron is moving towards the detector at any time.

The slits are marked δ_1 and δ_2 .

Δ be some arbitrary region on the electron detector.

Let Y_1 and Y_2 be the projection operators for position in the regions of the two slits δ_1 and δ_2 . Then $Y_1 + Y_2$ is the projection of position for the union $\delta_1 \cup \delta_2$. Let X be the operator for position in a local region Δ on the detection screen. Assume the electron is only constrained to pass through the slits without being constrained as to which, then under those conditions the conditional probability is given by the Law of Alternatives:

$$p(X|Y_1 + Y_2) = p(X|Y_1)p(Y_1|Y_1 + Y_2) + p(X|Y_2)p(Y_2|Y_1 + Y_2) + \frac{\text{tr}(Y_1 \rho Y_2 X) + \text{tr}(Y_2 \rho Y_1 X)}{\text{tr}(\rho(Y_1 + Y_2))}. \quad (1)$$

This can be written more compactly as

$$p(X|Y_1 + Y_2) = p(X|Y_1)p(Y_1|Y_1 + Y_2) + p(X|Y_2)p(Y_2|Y_1 + Y_2) + p(X|Y_1 + Y_2)_I \quad (2)$$

where $p(X|Y_1 + Y_2)_I$ is the interference term.

Note that if X commutes with either Y_1 or Y_2 , this interference term vanishes, because $Y_i Y_j = 0$ for $i \neq j$. This can be observed if the detector is right next to the two-slit screen because X then coincides with either Y_1 or Y_2 . If the detector is a distance from the two-slit screen (e.g. $X = \Delta$), then the state of the electron evolves unitarily via α_t , so $\alpha_t(Y_i) = u_t Y_i u_t^{-1}$ no longer commutes with $\alpha(X)$, giving rise to the non-zero interference term.

The standard explanation of the interference effect is that the state of the particle is, or acts as, a coherent pair of waves emanating from the slits, which exhibit constructive and destructive interference effects. This was, of course, the explanation for Young's original experiment with light. For individual quantum particles, however, there is the unexplained local event observed at the detection screen. This is a problem for the theory. While the Born interpretation of the wavefunction provides a probability distribution for the particle position it requires the detection screen, operating outside what is described by the mathematical theory, to act as a sampling mechanism for that distribution.

The explanation given in this blog is that the two-slit screen functions as a preparation of the state for the particle, by which the state is conditioned, or reduced, to pass through the region $\delta_1 \cup \delta_2$. This reduction is not a position measurement, since $\delta_1 \cup \delta_2$ is not a localised region (as it would be for a single-slit screen). Once the particle reaches a detection screen then, in interaction with the screen, it appears in a random local region Δ and its position takes a value. Just as in the standard Born interpretation of the wavefunction, it is not explained in the theory how the electron takes the value that the detector detects other than invoking random sampling of the possible values.

So, the interference pattern on the detector is built up over time as more electrons arrive and are sampled by the detector.

3.2 The introduction of an interaction with a pointer

This section is adapted from Bricmont (2017), Appendix 5.A and Maudlin (2019).

The experiment, illustrated in Figure (2), is now as follows:

There is again a source of electrons that move towards a screen with two slits.

The intensity of the beam is low and only one electron is moving towards the detector at any time.

The slits are marked δ_1 and δ_2 .

Δ be some arbitrary region on the electron detector.

A pointer P is introduced. It is a quantum object with three states: neutral P_0 , points to slit 1 (P_1), and points to slit 2 (P_2). The interaction with the electron causes the pointer to move towards it.

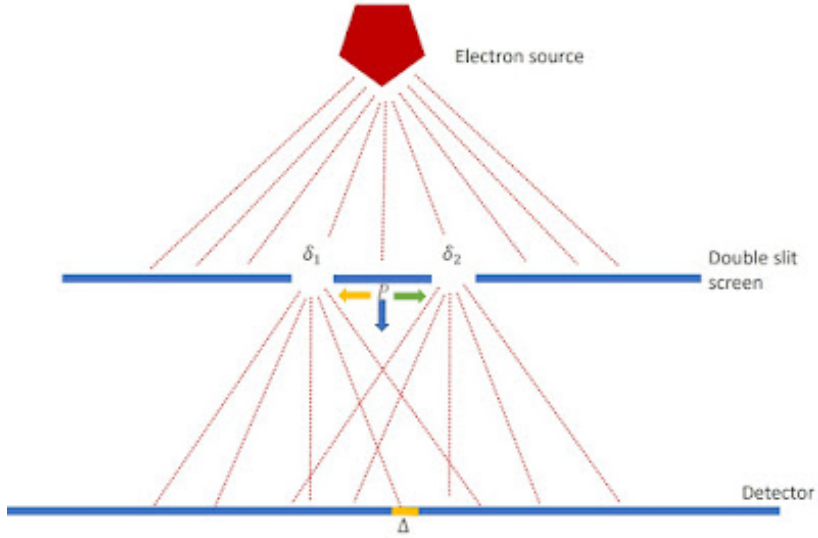


Figure 3.2: Figure (2) The setup for the double slit experiment is as in Figure (1) but for the addition of a three state pointer that interacts with the electron as it passes through slit δ_1 or δ_2 .

Again let Y_1 and Y_2 be the projection operators for position in the regions of the two slits δ_1 and δ_2 . Then $Y_1 + Y_2$ is the projection of position for the union $\delta_1 \cup \delta_2$. Let X be the operator for position in a local region Δ on the detection screen. The operator representing the pointer has three eigenstates and therefore a three-dimensional Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}_P$. Without the pointer the Hilbert space is $\mathcal{H}_0$. The Hilbert space of the total system is $\mathcal{H}_P \otimes \mathcal{H}_0$.

The possible constituent states are:

- ϕ_1 pointer pointing to slit δ_1
- ϕ_2 pointer pointing to slit δ_2
- ϕ_0 pointer neutral
- ψ_1 electron through slit δ_1
- ψ_2 electron through slit δ_2
- Ψ_0 electron with pointer in neutral state P_0

Assuming the pointer starts in its neutral state, the initial wave function is

$$\begin{aligned}\Psi_0 &= \phi_0 \otimes (\psi_1 + \psi_2) \\ &= \phi_0 \otimes \psi_1 + \phi_0 \otimes \psi_2\end{aligned}$$

3.3 Treatment I: Pointer reacts to which slit the electron passes through

Time evolution gives:

$$\Psi = \phi_1 \otimes \psi_1 + \phi_2 \otimes \psi_2.$$

The interference term becomes:

$$p(X|Y_1 + Y_2)_I = \frac{\text{tr}(Y_1 \rho_\Psi Y_2 X) + \text{tr}(Y_2 \rho_\Psi Y_1 X)}{\text{tr}(\rho_\Psi (Y_1 + Y_2))}$$

Using orthogonality of pointer states:

$$p(X|Y_1 + Y_2)_I = 0$$

Interference disappears.

3.4 Treatment II: Pointer does *not* react to which slit the electron passes through

General evolution:

$$\Psi = \sum_{i \in \{0,1,2\}} a_i \phi_i \otimes \psi_1 + \sum_{i \in \{0,1,2\}} b_i \phi_i \otimes \psi_2$$

with

$$a_0 = b_0, \quad a_1 = b_2, \quad a_2 = b_1.$$

The detection pattern is:

$$\begin{aligned} (\Psi, P \otimes X \Psi) &= \sum_i |a_i|^2 (\psi_1, X \psi_1) \\ &+ \sum_i |a_i|^2 (\psi_2, X \psi_2) + \sum_i a_1^* a_2 (\psi_2, X \psi_1) + \sum_i a_2^* a_1 (\psi_1, X \psi_2) \end{aligned}$$

Let $C = \sum_i |a_i|^2$:

$$(\Psi, P \otimes X \Psi) = C[(\psi_1, X\psi_1) + (\psi_2, X\psi_2)] + \text{Re}\{2a_1^* a_2 (\psi_2, X\psi_1)\}.$$

Interference persists.

4 Locality, Microcausality, and Entanglement

Until now, I have concentrated on trying to free quantum mechanics, as far as possible, from reference to measurement but quantum mechanics also has a problem with locality. However, firstly it is worth remembering that classical mechanics also had a locality problem. This is exemplified by the Newton's theory of gravity followed by Coulomb's law of electric charge attraction and repulsion. In both cases any local change in mass or charge, whether magnitude or position, had an instantaneous effect everywhere. There was no mechanism in the physics for propagation of the effect. The solution to this was found first for electricity in combination with magnetism. Faraday proposed the existence of a field. The mathematical formulation of this concept by Maxwell led to the classical electromagnetic theory and provided a propagation mechanism.

The success of electromagnetic theory brought to the fore two problems with classical dynamics. The space and time translation invariance in classical Newtonian dynamics did not follow the same transformation rules as in the electromagnetic theory and there was still no mechanism for the propagation of gravitational effect. As is well known, Einstein solved both anomalies with first his special and then his general theory of relativity.

By the time the general theory of relativity was formulated it was evident that classical theory had a further deep problem; it could not explain atomic and other micro phenomena. To tackle this problem solutions were found for specific situations. Max Plank introduced his constant $\hbar$ to resolve the problem of the ultraviolet singularity in the black body radiation spectrum through energy quantisation. This same constant came to be fundamental in explaining atomic energy levels, the photoelectric effect role and more generally the quantisation of action.

Quantum theory took shape in the 1920's with the rival formulations that agreed with experiment, by Heisenberg and Schrödinger (with much help from others), shown to be formally equivalent. The space time translation symmetry of special relativity was also built into an equation for the electron proposed by Dirac that in turn implies the existence of anti-matter. But a fully relativistic quantum mechanics remains a research topic.

To combine particle theory with electromagnetism quantum electrodynamics was developed. This theory was remarkably successful in its empirical confirmation but relied on some dubious mathematical manipulation. To deal with this the mathematical foundations of quantum field theory were examined. It is at this point that the first type of locality that we are going to consider appears in quantum theory in mathematically precise form.

4.1 Causal Locality

A basic characteristic of physics in the context of special relativity and general relativity is that causal influences on a Lorentzian manifold spacetime propagate in timelike or light-like directions but not space-like. Space-like separated points in space-time lie

outside each other's light cone, which means that no influence can pass from one to the other.

A further way of considering causality is that influences only propagate into the future in time-like and light-like directions, but this is not simple to deal with in either classical special relativity or standard quantum mechanics because of their time reversal symmetry. One approach would be to treat irreversible processes through coarse-grained entropy in statistical physics. But this seems more like a mathematical trick or treats irreversibility because of a lack of access to the detailed microscopic reversible dynamics. That is, as an illusion. A more fundamental approach is to develop a new physics as is being attempted by Fröhlich (2021) and hopefully in this book.

To return to Einstein causality, any two space-like-separated regions of spacetime should behave like independent subsystems. This causal locality is, with a slightly stronger technical definition, Einstein causality. This concept of locality when adopted in relativistic quantum theory (algebraic theory) implies that space-like separated local self-adjoint operators commute. This is sometimes known as microcausality. Microcausality is causal locality at the atomic level and below.

In quantum theory, where operators represent physical quantities, the microcausality condition requires that any operators commute that pertain to two points of space-time if these points cannot be linked by light propagation. This commutation means, as in standard quantum mechanics, that the physical quantities to which these operators correspond can be precisely determined locally, independently, and simultaneously. However, the operators in standard quantum theories and the non-relativistic alternatives discussed so far in this blog don't have a natural definition of an operator that is local in space-time. For example, the position

operator is not at any point in space. The points in space are held as potential values in the quantum state that is represented mathematically by the density matrix. How these potential values become actual is dealt with in standard quantum mechanics by the Born criterion, which is, however, tied to measurement situations. To remove this dependence on measurement situations is a major aim of this blog and we will see that measurement only need be invoked when discussing how various form of locality and non-locality are known about.

As the introduction of classical fields cured Newtonian dynamics of action at a distance and eventually modified then replaced it with General Relativity, the development of quantum field theory could cure standard quantum mechanics of its causal locality problem. Local quantum theory as set out in the book by Haag (1996) tackles this challenge. The technical details involved are too advanced to deal with here.

Although dealing with these questions coherently within non-relativistic quantum theory is not strictly valid it is possible to explore specific examples. Following Fröhlich (2023), it is natural to consider the spin of the particle to be local to that particle. Therefore, the spin operators, whether represented by Pauli matrices or by projection operators that project states associated with some subsets of the spin spectrum, can be assigned unambiguously to one particle or another.

In a situation where two particles are prepared so that they propagated in opposite directions their local interactions with other entities will eventually be space-like separated. The spin operators of one commute with the spin operators of the other. The local interaction of one cannot then be influence by the local interaction of the other. This is a specific example of microcausality.

But what if the preparation of the two particles entangles their quantum states? This entanglement may persist over any subsequent separation, if the particle does not first undergo any interaction with other particles or fields.

We note that entanglement is a state property whereas micro-causality is an operator property and proceed to a discussion of entanglement and its consequences in a developed version of the two-particle example.

4.2 Entanglement and Non-Locality

The two-particle example we have been discussing only needs the introduction of a local spin measurement mechanism for each particle for it to become the version of the Einstein Podolsky, Rosen thought experiment formulated by Bohm and Hiley (2006). This post will follow Bohm's mathematical treatment closely but will avoid as far as possible invoking the results of measurements. Bohm's discussion follows the Copenhagen interpretation but also uses the concept of potentiality as developed by Heisenberg (1958).

The system in this example consists of experimental setups (described below) for two atoms (1 and 2) with spin 1/2 (up/down or $\pm\hbar$). The z direction spin aspect of the state of the total system consists of four basic wavefunctions:

$$|a\rangle = |+, z, 1\rangle|+, z, 2\rangle$$

$$|b\rangle = |-, z, 1\rangle|-, z, 2\rangle$$

$$|c\rangle = |+, z, 1\rangle|-, z, 2\rangle$$

$$|d\rangle = |- , z, 1\rangle|+ , z, 2\rangle$$

it will be shown below that although the choice of the z direction is convenient the results of the analysis do not depend on it.

If the total system is prepared in a zero-spin state, then it is represented by the linear combination:

$$|0\rangle = |c\rangle - |d\rangle \tag{1}$$

This correlation of the spin states of the particles is an example of quantum entanglement.

Each particle also has associated with its spin state a wavefunction that describes its motion and position. These space wavefunctions will not be shown explicitly here but are important conceptually because the particles always move away from each other. The description of the thought experiment is completed by each particle undergoing a Stern-Gerlach experimental interaction at space-like separated regions of space-time, as shown below.

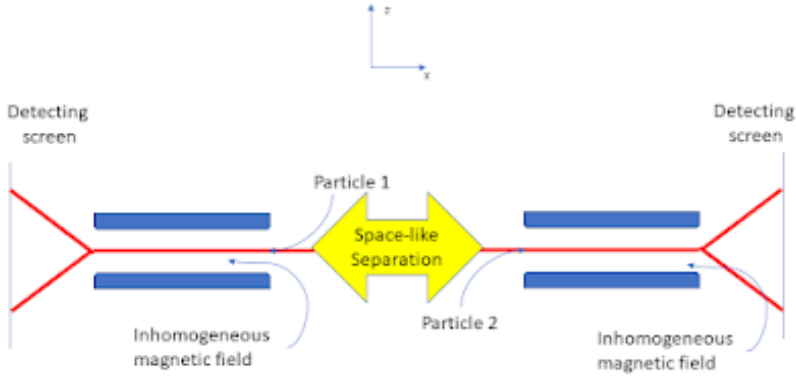


Figure 4.1: Two space-like separated Stern-Gerlach interaction situations.

The detecting screen is a part of an experimental setup that is need for confirming the predictions of the theory but not the physics of the effects. Here we are primarily concerned with the interaction of the particles with the magnetic field $\mathfrak{H}$. The component of the system Hamiltonian for the interaction of the particle spin with the magnetic field is, from Bohm (1951),

$$\mathcal{H} = \mu(\mathfrak{H}_0 + z_1\mathfrak{H}'_0)\sigma_{1,z} + \mu(\mathfrak{H}_0 + z_2\mathfrak{H}'_0)\sigma_{2,z}$$

where $\mu = \frac{e\hbar}{2mc}$, $\mathfrak{H}_0 = (\mathfrak{H}_z)_{z=0}$ and $\mathfrak{H}'_0 = (\frac{\partial \mathfrak{H}_z}{\partial z})_{z=0}$. m and e are the electron mass and charge. c is the speed of light in vacuum.

We also assume the magnetic fields have the same strength and spatial form in both regions but this not essential. It is also assumed that each particle interacts with its own local magnetic field at the same time. This is not a limiting assumption, but it is essential to assume that the time of the interaction is short enough for the local space-time regions to remain space-like separated.

The Schrödinger equation can now be solved for a wavefunction of the form

$$|\psi\rangle = f_c|c\rangle + f_d|d\rangle$$

with initial conditions given by equation (1). The result is, once the particles have passed through the region with non-zero magnetic field strength:

$$f_c = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}} e^{-i \frac{\mu \tilde{y}'_0}{\hbar} (z_1 - z_2) \Delta t}$$

and

$$f_d = -\frac{1}{\sqrt{2}} e^{i \frac{\mu \tilde{y}'_0}{\hbar} (z_1 - z_2) \Delta t}$$

Where Δt is the time it takes for the particles to pass through the magnetic field.

Inserting the above results into the equation for $|\psi\rangle$ gives the post interaction wavefunction:

$$|\psi\rangle = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}} e^{-i \frac{\mu \tilde{y}'_0}{\hbar} (z_1 - z_2) \Delta t} |c\rangle - \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}} e^{i \frac{\mu \tilde{y}'_0}{\hbar} (z_1 - z_2) \Delta t} |d\rangle$$

Therefore, for a system prepared with total spin zero undergoing local interactions in space-like separated regions, as shown in the figure, there is equal probability for each particle to be deflected either up or down. However, because of the correlation when one is deflected up the other is deflected down.

This may seem unsurprising because the total spin is prepared to be zero. No more surprising than taking a green card and a blue card, putting them in identical envelopes, shuffling them and then giving one to a friend to take far away. Opening the envelope you kept and seeing a green card means that the distant envelope contains a blue card. This, clearly, is not a non-local influence.

However, this is not the end of the story. As mentioned above, there is nothing special about the z direction of spin. The same analysis can be carried with x direction states, as follows:

$$\begin{aligned} |a'\rangle &= |+, x, 1\rangle |+, x, 2\rangle \\ |b'\rangle &= |-, x, 1\rangle |-, x, 2\rangle \\ |c'\rangle &= |+, x, 1\rangle |-, x, 2\rangle \\ |d'\rangle &= |-, x, 1\rangle |+, x, 2\rangle \end{aligned}$$

and again, the zero total spin state is:

$$|0'\rangle = |c'\rangle - |d'\rangle \tag{2}$$

Using the standard spin state relations (valid for both particles one and two, by introducing the appropriate tags (1 or 2), see Bohm (1951):

$$|+, x\rangle = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}(|+, z\rangle + |-, z\rangle) \quad \text{and} \quad |-, x\rangle = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}(|+, z\rangle - |-, z\rangle)$$

Inserting into equation (2), with some algebra, it can be shown that:

$$|0'\rangle = |0\rangle$$

Therefore, if the Stern-Gerlach setup is rotated to measure the x component of spin, exactly the same analysis can be carried out as for the z component giving the same anti-correlation effect. It must be stressed that we are discussing physical effects and not the results of experiments or the experimenter's knowledge of events at this point.

In general, there is no reason for the two space-like separated setups to be chosen in the same direction. If the choice is effectively random then when the direction of interaction does not coincide there will be no correlation between the outcomes but if they happen to be in the same direction, then there will be the $\pm$ anti-correlation. Locally the spin operators for the x, y and z do not commute. Their values are potential rather than actual and remain non-actual after the interactions. The situation is not like the classical coloured cards in envelopes example. There is no direction of spin fixed by the initial state preparation. Indeed, that would be inconsistent with a total spin zero state preparation. What the interaction does is chose a σ -algebra from the local σ -complex but the spin state of the system remains entangled.

As far as local effects are concerned, each particle behaves as expected for a spin 1/2 particle. This is causal locality. It is only if someone gets access to a sequence of measurements

from both regions (here is the only place where detection enters this description of the physics of this situation) that the anti-correlation effect can be confirmed.

The effect depends on the preparation of the initial total system state. There is persistent correlation across any distance just as in the green and blue card example, but it is mysterious because the initial state does not hold an actual value of each spin component for each particle, unlike the actuality green and blue card example. There is no way for the one particle to be influenced by the choice of direction of measurement at the region where the other particle is, but a correlation of potentiality persists that depends on the details of the total quantum state.

It is perhaps too early to simply accept that there are non-causal, non-classical correlations of potentialities between two space-like separated regions. That would be a quantum generalisation of the blue and green card example. What the theory does predict is that the effect due to entanglement is not just epistemic but physical once potentiality is accepted as an aspect of the ontology.

5 Comparison of quantum physical ontologies

In discussing ontology in physics both the real and ideal spheres, as introduced by Nicolai Hartmann, play a role. The pure mathematics, applied to construct theory, is in the ideal sphere and the physical entities are in the real sphere. For example, self-adjoint operators exist in quantum theory and they represent observables (properties of things) that exist (this is claimed as a truth) in the physical world. However, it must always be kept in mind that truth claims are fallible.

The ontologies discussed in this chapter are proposals for what exists and does not exist in real sphere interpretations of several formulations of quantum mechanics. These proposals are to be contrasted with the aspect of critical ontology that provides the structures for the investigation. A guiding statement, in the spirit of critical ontology, for this investigation, is that by Maudlin (2019):

A physical theory should clearly and forthrightly address two fundamental questions: what there is, and what it does. This section explores a range of options on ‘what there is’ in theories that seek to produce identical or very similar empirical results. If the empirical results were not in agreement, then those theories

that did not agree with experiment would be eliminated as not being true, although they could still be of theoretical interest. It is because theories with radically different existence claims can have the same empirical consequences that ontology investigation is interesting and relevant.

In what follows familiarity with standard quantum physics, as taught to physics undergraduates, is assumed. If a reminder is needed then Jennan Ismael's contribution to The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy (Ismael 2021) may be helpful.

In the multi-strata model of the real, the discussion that follows deals with physical entities in the inorganic layer. The theories are creations than reside in the objective part of the spiritual layer. There are theories that involve the psychic layer but they will not be considered in this chapter. The psychic layer can only come into play if there is someone there to have perceptions and thoughts.

5.1 Local beables

John Bell (Bell 2004a), uses his concept of local beables (Bell 2004b) to propose that theses random events are what give effect to local beables. Bell's local beables are a significant development as it was a move away from focusing on what is observed to what exists. The locality of the beable, however, is still tied to the observation that particles such as electrons or photons appear locally in experimental situations. *Beable* also implies a process of coming into being. So, a particle may exist in an interaction or detection but what of the existence of the particle as such?

The concept of local beables in general leaves such questions unanswered. The application to GRW will now be considered.

5.2 Wavefunction ontology

In standard quantum physics the wavefunction permits a range of possible events. Of the possible events one happens due to a measurement process. But what happens - what is the physics - when there is no measurement? Ghirardi, Rimini and Weber (Ghirardi et al. 1986), (GRW) introduced a supplementary physical effect to standard quantum mechanics that randomly causes the collapse of the wavefunction, creating a way of obtaining macroscopic events from microscopic quantum systems, as will be explained below.

The GRW mechanism is as follows. Let the initial the wave function be

$$\psi(t, q_1, q_2, \dots, q_N)$$

t is time and $q_1, q_2, \dots, q_N$ are position coordinates. The probability per unit time for a GRW spontaneous collapse event is N/τ , where τ is a new constant of nature, chosen to be in the order of 10^{14} seconds. The collapsed wavefunction is

$$\psi' = \frac{j(x - q_n)\psi(t, \dots)}{R_n(x)},$$

where q_n is chosen at random (probability = $1/N$)

The definition of the weighting function j introduces at least one further constant of nature. This is tuned to be in the region

of 10^{-5}cm to preserve the observed microscopic effects while generating the commonly observed macroscopic world. There is nothing but the wavefunction and the collapse is part of its dynamics.

However, the GRW collapse events happen to the wavefunction, not something else. The wavefunction is then well localized in ordinary space at, at most, a mesoscopic scale. Each is centred on a particular space-time point (x, t) . So, Bell proposes these events as providing the local beables of the theory. This would make the beables appearances of the object (Sosein) not a representation of the object itself (Dasein). That being so, these local beables are sparse events in a system of particles and would be very rare for a small number of particles. That is, in the time scales typical of experiment nothing would happen outside the detector. Entanglement provides the mechanism for the commonly experienced existence of macroscopic bodies such as detectors. Note that the spontaneous event is a reduction of the wavefunction. This leaves open the relationship to the charge, mass and spin carrying particle. In addition, if this spontaneously reduced wavefunction is what exists then its relation to the actual particle still needs explanation. Implicitly there is a return to Born probability mechanism but without clarity on this the ontology is incomplete.

5.2.1 Distributed charge and mass

An alternative wavefunction ontology, but still within GRW theory, proposes that the particle has only a “fuzzy” position, with “more of it” located in places that correspond to its location in configurations which are assigned high amplitudes by the wavefunction. This suggests a picture in which the particle is “smeared

out” in space, and the effect of the GRW hit is to concentrate most of the smear within 10^{-5} cm of a particular location. In this ontology the charge and mass of an electron would presumably be distributed across the support of the wavefunction. This theory does propose that a particle exists as such and is extended in space. This therefore provides a more complete ontology.

5.2.2 The multiverse

A third set of theories are a development of Everett’s relative state formulation of quantum mechanics (Everett 1957), that are commonly known as many worlds or multiverse interpretations. In this case just the evolving wavefunction features as the candidate entity. The wave function describes all the possibilities for the system and all possibilities happen. This gives rise to many (an infinity of) physical worlds. Wallace (2012) provides a comprehensive discussion of this set of theories.

Everett’s criterion for the real existence of a branch is: If the wavefunction ψ of a system is a superposition $a\phi + b\theta$ then the “branches” ϕ and θ exist, and in each branch, everything physically exists that would exist if that were the entire state of the system. However, there are many ways to represent a function as a linear representation of other functions. Some further structure is required to provide a path to candidates for entities. One approach is an appeal to decoherence, achieved through entanglement. Here the quantity capturing possible states of affairs is $|\psi|^2$ and entanglement can pick out specific decomposition that depends on the physics of the interaction bohmhiley2006

$$|\psi|^2 \rightarrow |a\phi|^2 + |b\theta|^2$$

That is, there is no interference term. However, the more detailed theory (Wallace 2012) works with approximate decoherence.

Examining critically the ontology of many worlds, it shares some of the issues with the GRW theory, especially in the Bell beables version. The smeared, or extended particle interpretation is not available to it but a complete theory must show how familiar phenomena emerge.

A macro-object is a pattern, and the existence of a pattern as a real thing depends on the usefulness—in particular the explanatory power and predictive reliability—of theories which admit that pattern in their ontology.

What makes a collection of electrons, protons, and neutrons a particle accelerator, rather than something else, has to do with how the microscopic parts are arranged, or structured. A significant part of that structure is the spatial arrangement of the microscopic parts through time. However, a quantum wavefunction contains no microscopic parts localized in space-time, so its behaviour cannot create a macroscopic particle accelerator in anything like the way the behaviour of localized electrons, neutrons, and protons can. The problem remains of how to populate familiar space-time with locally existing entities.

5.3 Bohmian ontology

Bohmian mechanics (Bohm and Hiley 2006), (Dürr and Teufel 2009), is a formulation of quantum mechanics that is constructed to give the same results as that of standard quantum mechanics but in which particles have continuous trajectories. For a discussion of the theory's ontology the mathematics of how this is accomplished is not relevant. The ontology includes:

- Particles with a well-defined position $x(t)$ which varies continuously and is causally determined.
- A guiding field that is derived from the solution of Schrödinger's equation, so that it too changes continuously and is causally determined.
 - The particle is never separate from this guiding field that fundamentally affects it. There is no dynamics without this field.
 - The guiding field is not affected by the particle.

The Bohmian mechanics emphasises that the particle has a continuous trajectory and that these trajectories exist in the physical domain. The particle does not follow the laws of classical dynamics but is guided by a field that is directly derived from the solution to the Schrödinger equation. The claims made about what exists are not made within a wider ontology, but simply posit particles and guiding fields. It is tacitly assumed that to exist is to physically exist.

The distinction has been made between existing in the theory (the ideal sphere) and existing physically (the real sphere). There is a version Bohmian mechanics in which the guiding field is not in the real sphere of the ontology but in the ideal sphere. The guiding field is then a law governing the behaviour of the particle but not a physical entity like the particle. Allori (2013) presents this as a primitive ontology. Allori claims that a physical theory

... will be about a given primitive ontology: entities living in three-dimensional space or in space-time. They are the fundamental building blocks of everything else, and their histories through time provide a picture of the world according to the theory (the scientific image).

These primitive variables describe what exists in the inorganic layer of the real sphere whereas non-primitive variables exist in the physical theories in the ideal sphere. In a physical situation where no person is active there is no mechanism for the ideal sphere to influence the real sphere. The primitive ontology must therefore include the guiding field so that Bohmian mechanics can operate as a fully-fledged physical theory. However, the wavefunction that gives rise to the guiding field is a function on configuration space, rather than the three-dimensional space of natural phenomena.

5.4 Conclusion

Critical ontology, as an investigative method, has now been applied to a range of proposals that claim the physical existence of particle or wavefunctions or both. Of these it is Bohmian mechanics, with particles and guiding fields as physical entities, that provides the most near to complete physical ontology.

A major deficiency in GRW theories is that the ontological status of the spontaneous reduction of the wavefunction. The mathematical description is of a stochastic process but it is not clear what this process is a property of. This will need a discussion of dispositional properties.

6 Introduction to Physical Ontology

Quantum mechanics is part of physics and experimentation is an activity in physics. Therefore, the entities of interest in physics must be observable to some extent. They must make an appearance. That is, entities of interest must be **objects**; they appear in at least one **field of sense**.

The ontological framework for the discussion will be that quantum objects are physical objects that have some properties that can appear in one of a collection of fields of sense. To move from ontology to physical theory, an explanatory structure is needed and, when possible, a mathematical formulation is adopted that describes the behavior of the quantum objects in a precise way.

6.1 The Problem of Contextuality

There are puzzling and paradoxical effects of quantum mechanics, be they the thought experiments of Einstein, Podolsky and Rosen (EPR) or Wigner's friend with Schrödinger's cat, or even double-slit experiment. These effects to the need to re-examine what is meant by a **physical property** of an object.

In quantum mechanics, it is known that all properties need a specific context in which to appear as quantified values. This is

known to be the case in general from the work of **Kochen and Specker** (Kochen and Specker 1967), but has been a common understanding among physicists based on insights obtained from experiments such as that of **Stern and Gerlach** (Gerlach and Stern 1922).

6.2 Position, Momentum, and the Field of Sense

Before moving on to spin, consider the **Heisenberg Uncertainty Principle**, which is usually taken to mean that an electron, for example, cannot have a precise value of its position and its momentum at the same time.

Question: Does this mean that it sometimes has position as a property and sometimes momentum but never both together?

That understanding of the theory would mean that these properties are of the context rather than the object of the experiment. According to the ontology of objects and their properties being developed here, a particle (such as an electron) always has the properties of position and momentum, represented by an operator, but these properties take values by appearing in distinct **Fields of Sense**. This means that the context in which the particle position takes a value is different from that in which its momentum takes a value.

6.3 Mathematical Formulation of Spin

We now consider a particle with spin $1/2$ (an electron) situated and free to move in three dimensions. Following Faddeev and Yakubovskii (2000), the electron combines its spin Hilbert space ($\mathbb{C}^2$) with that associated with the electron's movement in three dimensions ($\mathbb{R}^3$).

The Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}$ for the electron's position and momentum is the space $L^2(\mathbb{R}^3)$ of square-integrable complex-valued functions. In mathematical notation, the state space with spin becomes the enlarged Hilbert space:

$$\mathcal{H}_S = L^2(\mathbb{R}^3) \otimes \mathbb{C}^2$$

This captures the intuition that the state function becomes a pair of complex-valued $L^2(\mathbb{R}^3)$ functions. For a pure state $\Psi(x)$ in $\mathcal{H}$, there are two orthogonal states in $\mathcal{H}_S$:

$$\Psi_{\uparrow} = \begin{pmatrix} \Psi(x) \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}, \Psi_{\downarrow} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ \Psi(x) \end{pmatrix}$$

6.3.1 Spin Operators and Pauli Matrices

Focusing on the spin property $\hat{S}$, a self-adjoint operator S on $\mathbb{C}^2$ can be represented as the linear combination of the identity matrix I and the **Pauli matrices**:

$$I = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \sigma_1 = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \sigma_2 = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & -i \\ i & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \sigma_3 = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & -1 \end{pmatrix}$$

Quantum physics is brought into this mathematics by introducing the Planck constant $\hbar$ and defining the self-adjoint spin-1/2 operators as:

$$S_j = \frac{\hbar}{2} \sigma_j, \quad j = 1, 2, 3 \quad (1)$$

These follow the angular momentum commutation relations:

$$[S_1, S_2] = i\hbar S_3, \quad [S_2, S_3] = i\hbar S_1, \quad [S_3, S_1] = i\hbar S_2$$

6.4 Spin Eigenvalues and State Vectors

The operators S_j have eigenvalues $\pm\hbar/2$, which are the admissible values of the projections of the spin on some direction. The vectors

$$\Psi_{\uparrow} = \begin{pmatrix} \Psi(x) \\ 0 \end{pmatrix} \quad \text{and} \quad \Psi_{\downarrow} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ \Psi(x) \end{pmatrix}$$

are eigenvectors of the operator S_3 with eigenvalues $+\hbar/2$ and $-\hbar/2$.

The eigenvectors of S_1 and S_2 are linear combinations of $\Psi_{\uparrow}$ and $\Psi_{\downarrow}$. Therefore, these vectors describe states with a definite value of the third projection of the spin. Similar constructions can be made for the other spin components.

6.5 Non-Commutativity and Interaction

As the components do not commute, they cannot simultaneously take precise values in all components. The spin will appear to interact with some other object, involving a magnetic interaction, to take a value of $+\hbar/2$ or $-\hbar/2$. Independent of the direction defined by the interaction, the possible values the spin property can take are $\pm\hbar/2$, with probabilities determined by the state of the electron. The probabilities of $\pm\hbar/2$ appearing sum to one.

The property values appear when the appropriate **Field of Sense** is available. However, in relation to this point it should be noted that the isolated system has properties represented by Hermitian operators, such as the spin-1/2 S_j , that have eigenvalues $\pm\frac{1}{2}\hbar$ even in the absence of any interaction term coupling it to another object.

The spin values are quantitative characteristics of the spin property, but the values will only actually **appear** once the appropriate Field of Sense is available to provide a context for an interaction with another object.

The spin will appear to interact with some other object (involving a magnetic interaction) to take a value. A **Field of Sense** affords a context for the appearance of properties of the quantum object. The values only actually appear once the appropriate Field of Sense is available to provide a context for an interaction with another object.

7 The Combination of Quantum Objects

Quantum objects have been introduced in an earlier chapter. These objects, if not the most fundamental entities, are quite basic to the constitution of the inorganic layer of reality. In contributing to the complexity of the real world these objects must combine.

Many calculations in quantum mechanics can be carried out by considering a single isolated system and its the operator representing the total energy of the system - the Hamiltonian. That is how the spectrum of the Hydrogen atom is calculated and how tunnelling is analysed. However, it is especially important in examining contextual issues to consider mathematical representation of the combination and interaction of objects. Having introduced the concept of the σ -complex for an isolated system, the σ -complex of two systems S_1 and S_2 will now be constructed.

As is standard in the von Neumann formulation (Neumann 1932), if the Hilbert spaces $\mathcal{H}_1$ associated with object S_1 and $\mathcal{H}_2$ associated with object S_2 , the Hilbert space of the combined object $S_1 + S_2$ is the tensor product $\mathcal{H}_1 \otimes \mathcal{H}_2$.

Given the combined system $S_1 + S_2$ with the σ -complex $Q(\mathcal{H}_1) \oplus Q(\mathcal{H}_2)$, there is a unique Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}_1 \otimes \mathcal{H}_2$ such that $Q(\mathcal{H}_1) \oplus Q(\mathcal{H}_2) \cong Q(\mathcal{H}_1 \otimes \mathcal{H}_2)$, where $\cong$ means equivalence

unique up to isomorphism. For the proof, in finite dimensional Hilbert spaces, see Kochen (2015).

The combination of two quantum objects gives a quantum object. This would build up a world consisting only of quantum objects. Is this the case or do the quantum characteristics weaken with many combinations? We will return to this question.

8 Quantum chance

In contrast to other formulations of quantum mechanics, the theory proposed here describes a world of objective chance events.

8.1 Quantum States

As presented in an earlier chapter, the properties of a quantum object are represented by self-adjoint operators, and these operators act on the elements of a Hilbert space. The concept of the state of a quantum system or object will now be presented. This concept of state is closely aligned with that in statistical mechanics, but the probabilistic quantum state is a property of an individual object rather than a statistical ensemble. As quantum states generalize classical probabilities, the discussion starts with a brief overview of probability measures.

8.1.1 Probability Measures

Classical probability (Kolmogorov 2018) provides a probability measure—a countably additive, $[0, 1]$ -valued measure—that is a function:

$$p : B \rightarrow [0, 1]$$

with domain B , a σ -algebra of subsets of the state space Ω , such that $p(\mathbf{1}) = 1$, where $\mathbf{1}$ is the identity in the algebra B , and:

$$p\left(\bigcup_i e_i\right) = \sum_i p(e_i) \quad \text{for pair-wise disjoint elements } e_1, e_2, \dots \text{ in } B.$$

In the case of a system $\mathbf{S}$, an object more complex than a single particle, the probability function p gives the probabilities over the σ -algebra of events for that system as a whole. A physical theory predicts the probabilities of outcomes of any possible situation given the complete initial state.

States of a system $\mathbf{S}$ in quantum mechanics are, in general, represented by density matrices acting on a Hilbert space, $\mathcal{H}_{\mathbf{S}}$. Density matrices are non-negative, trace-class operators, ρ , of trace 1, that is:

$$\rho = \rho^* \geq 0, \quad \text{with } \text{tr}(\rho) = 1.$$

The expectation of a physical quantity, $\hat{X} \in \mathcal{O}_{\mathbf{S}}$ (the set of properties for the system), at time t in a state given by a density matrix ρ is defined by:

$$p(X(t)) := \text{tr}(\rho X(t))$$

where $X(t)$ is the operator representing the physical property $\hat{X}(t)$. This can be extended to all bounded operators in $\mathcal{A}(\mathcal{H}_{\mathbf{S}})$, the $*$ -algebra of all bounded operators acting on $\mathcal{H}_{\mathbf{S}}$.

From the mathematical formulation by Kochen (Kochen 2015), adapted here, there is a one-to-one correspondence between states

p on the σ -complex $Q(\mathcal{H})$ and density operators. The use of the same symbol as for the classical event probability $p(x)$ for the quantum state is because this mathematical description of the quantum state is a generalization of the classical probability model from a single σ -algebra to a σ -complex. A density operator ρ defines a probability measure p on $Q(\mathcal{H})$, the σ -complex of projections. The converse, that a state p defines a unique density operator ρ on $\mathcal{H}$, follows from a theorem of Gleason (Gleason 1957). A state on the lattice of projections on $\mathcal{H}$ defines a unique density operator. A lattice consists of a partially ordered set in which every pair of elements has a unique least upper bound and a unique greatest lower bound.

8.1.2 Pure and Mixed States

In Quantum Mechanics, there is a one-to-one correspondence between the pure states of a system and rays of unit vectors ψ in $\mathcal{H}$, such that $p(X) = (\psi, X\psi)$. The pure states correspond to one-dimensional projections π_ψ (with ψ in the image of π_ψ) and $p(X) = \text{tr}(\pi_\psi X) = (\psi, X\psi)$.

That even the pure states predict probabilities that are not 0 or 1 is what is to be expected of projections onto property values. A pure state simply predicts the probabilities of property values that can become actual in interactions. Mixed states are mixtures of the pure states, and in general, there is no unique decomposition of a mixed state into pure states.

8.2 Properties or Observables

An observable is nothing more than a property of a quantum object that has a set of possible values that become actual values in interaction with other objects and can appear in various contexts. It need not actually be “observed” in an experiment to do so. In the theory, each such property is represented by a self-adjoint operator that has a spectrum that corresponds to the set of possible property values.

This concept of property can, as argued above, be treated within the σ -complex formulation (Kochen 2015). Kochen shows that there is a one-to-one correspondence between observables ω such that:

$$\omega : B(\mathbb{R}) \rightarrow Q(\mathcal{H}),$$

where $B(\mathbb{R})$ is the σ -algebra of Borel sets (any set in a topological space that can be formed from open sets, or from closed sets, through the operations of countable union, countable intersection, and relative complement is a *Borel set*) generated by the open intervals of the real numbers, $\mathbb{R}$.

Given $\pi_\lambda = \omega((-\infty, \lambda])$, there is a Hermitian operator A such that:

$$A = \int \lambda d\pi_\lambda.$$

Conversely, given a Hermitian operator A on $\mathcal{H}$, the spectral decomposition above defines the representation of a property ω as the spectral measure $\omega(s) = \int_s d\pi_\lambda$, for $s \in B(\mathbb{R})$. This establishes the one-to-one correspondence and the equivalence of

a key element of the reconstruction to that of standard quantum mechanics.

It follows that if $\omega : B(\mathbb{R}) \rightarrow Q(\Omega)$ is a representation of a property with corresponding self-adjoint operator X , then, for the state p with corresponding density operator ρ , the expectation of ω is:

$$\text{Exp}_p(\omega) = \text{tr}(X\rho).$$

The result shows the close connection between the spectrum of an operator and the σ -algebra of property values. For instance, for the case of a discrete operator X , the spectral decomposition $X = \sum a_i \pi_i$ defines the σ -algebra of property values generated by the set $\{\pi_i\}_i$. Conversely, given the σ -algebra of property values, the elements of the set $\{\pi_i\}_i$ allow the definition, for each sequence of real numbers a_i , of the Hermitian operator $\sum a_i \pi_i$.

8.3 Symmetries

In the standard formulation of quantum physics, symmetries appear as unitary transformations of Hilbert space vectors or Hermitian operators. Here they also appear naturally as symmetries of a σ -complex.

An automorphism of a σ -complex Q is a one-to-one transformation $\alpha : Q \rightarrow Q$ of Q onto Q such that for every σ -algebra B in Q and all $e, e_1, e_2, \dots$ in every B :

$$\alpha(e^\perp) = \alpha(e)^\perp \quad \text{and} \quad \alpha\left(\sum_i e_i\right) = \sum_i \alpha(e_i),$$

where $\perp$ denotes the orthogonal complement.

There is a one-to-one correspondence between symmetries $\alpha : Q(\mathcal{H}) \rightarrow Q(\mathcal{H})$ and unitary operators u on $\mathcal{H}$ such that $\alpha(X) = uXu^{-1}$, for all $X \in Q(\mathcal{H})$. If a state p corresponds to the density operator ρ , then:

$$p_\alpha(X) = p(\alpha^{-1}(X)) = \text{tr}(\rho u^{-1}Xu) = \text{tr}(u\rho u^{-1}X) \quad (*)$$

so that the state p_α corresponds to the density operator $u\rho u^{-1}$. This shows the mathematical equivalence between the σ -complex and the density matrix formulations under symmetry transformation.

Now that the mathematical formalism in terms of σ -complexes has been presented, it is possible to develop a theory that describes the micro-physical world as governed by quantum chance. By chance is meant objective probability that is a physical property of objects in the real sphere rather than a description of uncertainty in the epistemic sphere. This will, among other attributes, allow the derivation of the quantum conditional probability that provides an explanation of quantum state reduction.

In standard quantum mechanics, the term “reduction” usually means the reduction of the wavefunction and so is conceptually tied to the Schrödinger picture. Although there is a mathematical equivalence between the Schrödinger picture and the formalism developed in this paper, the state as a set of probability measures on a σ -complex of projection operators describes a physics of dispositions rather than waves in either real space or some more abstract space. As such, the position is closer to that of matrix mechanics of early quantum physics, but with more ontological detail on the role of probabilities.

8.3.1 Conditional States

State reduction is a phenomenon that may seem unique to quantum mechanics and has no counterpart in classical mechanics, but this is not the case. Conditional probability plays that role classically, but the objective ensemble or relative frequency interpretations of probability are available, which means that no conceptual problem is posed by the “reduction” of the probability distribution. With this in mind, conditional probability will now be generalized to quantum mechanics.

If p is a state on $Q(\mathcal{H})$ and Y a projection operator in $Q(\mathcal{H})$ such that $p(Y) \neq 0$, then it will be shown that there exists a unique state $p(\cdot | Y)$ conditional on Y . If ρ is the density operator corresponding to p , then to see that the operator $Y\rho Y/\text{tr}(Y\rho Y)$ corresponds to the state $p(\cdot | Y)$, note that if X lies in the same σ -algebra as Y , then X and Y commute, so:

$$\begin{aligned}\text{tr}(Y\rho YX)/\text{tr}(Y\rho Y) &= \text{tr}(\rho XY)/\text{tr}(\rho Y) \\ &= p(X \cdot Y)/p(Y) \\ &= p(X | Y),\end{aligned}$$

which is the standard form for conditional probability. It is proposed that the expression:

$$p(X | Y) = \text{tr}(Y\rho YX)/\text{tr}(Y\rho Y) \quad (**)$$

generalizes the conditional probability state to the case when X and Y do not commute.

The mapping of ρ to $Y\rho Y/\text{tr}(\rho Y)$ is the formula for the reduction of state given by the von Neumann-Lüders Projection Rule

(Lüders 1951). In standard quantum mechanics, this rule is an additional principle appended to quantum mechanics. Here it appears as the unique answer to conditioning a state to a specific projection operator.

From the symmetry transformation of the state, equation (*):

$$\begin{aligned}
 p_\alpha(X | Y) &= \frac{p_\alpha(XY)}{p_\alpha(Y)} \\
 &= \frac{p(\alpha^{-1}(XY))}{p(\alpha^{-1}(Y))} \\
 &= \frac{p(\alpha^{-1}(X)\alpha^{-1}(Y))}{p(\alpha^{-1}(Y))} \\
 &= p(\alpha^{-1}(X) | \alpha^{-1}(Y))
 \end{aligned}$$

The results in this subsection hold when X and Y are in the same commutative von Neumann sub-algebra corresponding to a sub- σ -algebra of $Q(\mathcal{H})$. The next subsection covers the more interesting case of when they are in different sub-algebras and there is a correction to the form of the conditional probability that is well known from classical probability.

8.3.2 Total Probability in Classical and Quantum Conditional Probability

The Law of Total Probability (or Law of Alternatives in the discrete case, as here) provides a useful method to partition and analyze conditional probabilities. Firstly, in the classical case, let $Y_1, Y_2, \dots$ lie in a $*$ -algebra of commuting projection operators with $Y_i Y_j = 0$ for $i \neq j$, and let $Y = \sum_i Y_i$, then:

$$\begin{aligned}
p(X | Y) &= p \left(\sum_i (XY_i) \right) / p(Y) \\
&= \sum_i (p(XY_i)/p(Y_i))(p(Y_i)/p(Y)) \\
&= \sum_i p(X | Y_i)p(Y_i | Y)
\end{aligned}$$

Not only is this partition useful, but it also displays clearly how the quantum case differs from the classical.

From equation (**), above:

$$\begin{aligned}
p(X | Y) &= \text{tr}(Y\rho YX)/\text{tr}(\rho Y) \\
&= \text{tr} \left(\sum_{i,j} Y_i \rho Y_j X \right) / \text{tr}(\rho Y) \\
&= \sum_i \text{tr}(Y_i \rho Y_i X) / \text{tr}(\rho Y) + \sum_{i \neq j} \text{tr}(Y_i \rho Y_j X) / \text{tr}(\rho Y) \\
&= \sum_i p(X | Y_i)p(Y_i | Y) + \sum_{i \neq j} \text{tr}(Y_i \rho Y_j X) / \text{tr}(\rho Y).
\end{aligned}$$

This shows that for conditional properties, an interference term must be added to the classical law of total probability. When X commutes with each Y_i , the interference term is zero.

A measurement of a property is the most familiar example of conditioning with respect to several properties. If a property represented by an operator A has a spectral decomposition $\sum_i a_i \pi_i$, then measuring the observable amounts to registering the values of the properties given by the π_i . The interaction algebra B_A is that generated by the π_i .

Conditioning can be used to define the context for the dynamics of a quantum object. In general, this requires the notion of conditioning with respect to several conditions.

Given a system with σ -complex Q and disjoint elements $Y_1, Y_2, \dots$ in a common σ -algebra in Q with $\sum_i Y_i = \mathbf{1}$, and a state p , the state conditional on $Y_1, Y_2, \dots$ is defined to be $p(\cdot \mid Y_1, Y_2, \dots) = \sum p(Y_i)p(\cdot \mid Y_i)$. This can be written more compactly as $p(\cdot \mid B_A)$, the state conditional on the interaction algebra B_A .

For a quantum system, with σ -complex $Q(\mathcal{H})$ and if ρ is the density operator corresponding to the state p :

$$p(\cdot \mid B_A) = \sum \text{tr}(\rho Y_i)(Y_i \rho Y_i / \text{tr}(\rho Y_i)) = \sum Y_i \rho Y_i,$$

so that for each X the probability $p(X \mid B_A) = \sum_i \text{tr}(Y_i \rho Y_i X)$.

The natural definition for applying a symmetry to the conditioned state is given by:

$$p_\alpha(X \mid B_A) = p(\alpha^{-1}(X) \mid \alpha^{-1}(B_A)).$$

The σ -algebra B_A generated by the $Y_1, Y_2, \dots$ is simply a sub-algebra of the σ -complex.

8.4 Summary

There is an equivalence between quantum states and the probabilities describing objective chance. That we are dealing with a generalization of probability theory is made evident in the equation for the conditional probability that introduces extra terms due to quantum interference.

9 Modal categories and quantum chance

9.1 Introduction

The motivation for examining modal categories is to provide a more refined account of the ontology of dispositions and chance in quantum mechanics. Therefore, the emphasis here will be on the *real sphere*, although the modes apply also in the *ideal sphere* but in a way appropriate to that sphere.

By analyzing how different interpretations of quantum theory handle the transitions between possibility, contingency, necessity, and actuality, we can uncover the underlying implicit ontologies that distinguish these frameworks.

9.2 The Hierarchy of Modal Categories

Following the ontological framework laid out by Nicolai Hartmann (1937), we distinguish between positive and negative modes of being. Intuitively, necessity is more than actuality, and actuality is more than possibility. This provides a clear sense of direction because the lower positive mode is contained within the higher:

Possibility $\subset$ Actuality $\subset$ Necessity.

What is actual must at least be possible, and what is necessary must at least be actual.

9.2.1 Positive Modes of Being

- **Necessity:** Not being able to be otherwise.
- **Actuality:** Being this way and not otherwise.
- **Possibility:** Being able to be one way or not.

9.2.2 Negative Modes of Being

Conversely, the negative modes offer descending degrees of definiteness and being: * **Contingency:** Not being necessary (also being able to be different). * **Non-actuality:** Not being so. * **Impossibility:** Not able to be so.

With the negative modes, **impossibility** is a minimum of being, representing extreme non-being. **Contingency** is fundamentally the non-existence of necessity. The definiteness of the way of being is less even in non-actuality than in contingency, and even less in impossibility than in non-actuality.

Of the three negative modes, it is **contingency** that will be the most significant for our needs in quantum mechanics because it is a border case with a trace of positivity, providing a minimum opening to *being-so*.

9.3 Modal Profiles of Quantum Interpretations

To illustrate how these modes apply, consider the measurement of a spin component of a quantum object. Empirically, it can take only one of two values: $\pm\hbar/2$. There are at least five descriptions of the world which are modally distinct in the real sphere.

9.3.1 Standard Quantum Mechanics

In standard quantum mechanics (Ismael 2021), it is contingent (not necessary) for a spin component to take only one of these two values. The language of “uncertainty” is inappropriate in a world described by standard quantum mechanics. The Heisenberg Uncertainty relationship, $\Delta x \Delta p \geq \hbar$, still hold of course but should be interpreted as a relationship between ranges of possibility for physical values. The values are not merely hidden; they have no *actual* being until they come into existence.

Standard quantum mechanics does not provide a mechanism to describe the transition from contingency to actuality. It goes no further than to describe possibilities and the probability of them becoming actual in a context.

9.3.2 Bohmian Mechanics

In a world described by Bohmian Mechanics (Dürr and Teufel 2009), the spin wavefunction guides the electron to take one of two values after following a determined trajectory. For every exact starting point of the electron, the end spin state is fully determined.

It is only due to the practical impossibility of determining the starting point that makes the spin value seem contingent. Therefore, it can be said to be **epistemically contingent** but not so in reality. In the exactly specified situation, the value that becomes actual does so **necessarily**.

9.3.3 Ghirardi–Rimini–Weber (GRW) Theory

9.3.3.1 Probabilistic Interpretation

If the world is as described by the Ghirardi, Rimini, and Weber (GRW) theory (Ghirardi et al. 1986) with the wavefunction still providing probabilities of outcomes, the ontological situation is structurally similar to standard quantum mechanics. This may seem puzzling because this theory is explicitly intended to dispel the mystery of quantum measurement (or, more generally, actuality). However, even after the spontaneous wavepacket reduction given by the GRW mechanism, some contingency remains; or, if the spin component value is actualized due to the spontaneous reduction, nothing is explained by it—it is merely posited.

9.3.3.1.1 Mass Density Interpretation

There is a distinct version of the GRW theory (Egg and Esfeld 2014) in which the wavefunction provides a **mass density** of the particle rather than a probability density. In typical situations, the mass density will spontaneously reduce to a physical configuration consistent with either $+\hbar/2$ or $-\hbar/2$.

9.3.4 The “Many-Worlds” Description

In the “Many-Worlds” description Wallace (2012), the world is infinitely larger than can be observed. Only one of an infinite set of sub-worlds is observable to us. The spin component takes both values on two sub-worlds that are empirically separate. Through correlation, it is known that if in one sub-world the spin takes the value $+\hbar/2$, then in the other it takes $-\hbar/2$. In this description of the world, all values are **actualized by necessity**.

9.3.5 Summary Matrix

Interpretation	Status of Outcomes	Ontological Category	Role of Chance
Standard QM	Contingent	Objective Real	Fundamental transition without physical mechanism
Bohmian Mechanics	Necessary	Epistemic	Practical ignorance of exact starting trajectories
GRW (Probabilistic)	Contingent / Posited	Objective Real	Spontaneous reduction mechanism
GRW (Mass Density)	Physically Reduced	Objective Real	Continuous physical transformation

Interpretation	Status of Outcomes	Ontological Category	Role of Chance
Many-Worlds	Necessary	Objective Real	Multi-verse branching across sub-worlds

9.4 3. Quantum Chance and the Problem of Actualization

When the mathematical formulation of quantum theory brings probabilities rather than wavefunctions to the fore, the term **chance** is used to mean objective random events rather than a state of uncertainty or partial belief. Before an event occurs, the complete description of the system is given by a probability measure.

Using these ontological terms, the probability measure over the σ -complex of the quantum system—an object in the *inorganic level of real being*—describes the objective chance that its properties (represented by self-adjoint operators) will take one of a spectrum of possibilities that will become actual in that same inorganic level of reality.

The probability measure describes a contingent mode of being for the quantum system with a spectrum of values that are possible and become actual. What remains missing is an understanding of the timing of the actualization.

Contingent Spectrum $\xrightarrow{\text{? Timing \& Physical Cause ?}}$ Actualized State

In all the versions of quantum theory considered so far, time behaves the same way as in classical physics. The timing of the actualization of the possible values of the observable and the physical cause (at the inorganic level of reality) of this actualization remains a major open problem.

The analysis of events in **quantum tunneling** may provide critical insight into this problem.

10 The Quantum Mechanics of Events, Histories and Trees

10.1 *Gemini feedback*

10.2 1. Foundations vs. Interpretation (Credo 1 & 2)

Your alignment here is crucial. Fröhlich’s insistence on “completing the foundations” rather than adding a loose philosophical gloss (“interpretation”) matches your goal of a generalized probability theory.

By demanding a “**structure-preserving map**” between mathematical symbols and concrete physical phenomena, Fröhlich is advocating for a strict mathematical realism. In your framework, this means that the complex of probability spaces cannot just be a computational trick; it must structurally map directly to how physical possibilities manifest.

10.3 2. The Ontological Friction: What Constitutes “What Is”? (Credo 3)

Your critique of paragraph (3) hits on a fundamental divide in modern quantum foundations: **Event/Process Ontology** vs. **Substance/State Ontology**.

- **Fröhlich’s View (Event-Ontology):** For the ETH school, the ultimate building blocks of reality are *events* and the *histories* they form. Objects like electrons, protons, or fields are secondary; they are essentially the structural rules or “bonds” that constrain which histories are possible. Reality is a verb, not a noun.
- **Your View (Substance/State-Ontology):** You argue that events cannot exist in a vacuum—there must be *things* (particles, fields, physical quantities) to which things happen. The atoms, fields, and their possible states must be granted ontological status.

10.3.1 Bridging the Gap

To reconcile this for your upcoming posts, consider this perspective: **Can your physical quantities be defined by the structure of the probability spaces themselves?** If an atom is “real,” its reality in an event-based framework might be represented by a invariant structural feature of the complex of probability spaces. The “thing” is the persistent topology of possibilities, while the “event” is the actualization of a point within that topology.

10.4 3. Mathematical Rigor as an Epistemic Guardrail (Credo 4 & 5)

Your defense of mathematical rigor against the “rigor for rigor’s sake” critique is vital. As you noted, Feynman warned us about fooling ourselves; mathematical rigor is the ultimate tool for exposing implicit, lazy assumptions.

In quantum mechanics, loose mathematics often hides the measurement problem behind vague terms like “environment” or “decoherence” without specifying *when* or *how* a definite outcome actually emerges. Fröhlich uses rigorous operator algebra (von Neumann algebras, specifically type III_1 factors in relativistic settings) to force the mathematics to tell us exactly when a possibility becomes an event.

10.5 Moving Forward: The Horizon of ETH

The six topics you listed at the end are the core battlegrounds of quantum foundations. As you dive into them, keep these specific questions in mind for your generalized probability theory:

- **On Loss of Predictability:** How does Fröhlich’s view of the future branching into trees match your network of probability spaces?
- **On Locality:** Does your complex of probability spaces naturally prevent faster-than-light signaling while maintaining quantum non-locality?

- **On the Nature of Events:** In ETH, an event occurs when a mathematical condition called the “**Information Loss Constraint**” is met. You will want to look at how this constraint can be translated into a property of your probability spaces.

Your approach of using ETH to patch the gaps in your own theory is an excellent methodology. It ensures you aren’t building in a vacuum, but rather testing your generalized probability theory against one of the most mathematically rigorous frameworks available today.

Which of the six topics from Fröhlich’s list do you plan to tackle first in your next post?

It sounds like you are laying the groundwork for a deeply rigorous and conceptually clean exploration of the **ETH Approach (Events, Trees, and Histories)**. Bridging your own work—where the quantum state is a complex of probability spaces—with Fröhlich’s framework is an excellent conceptual exercise.

Let’s break down your reflections on Fröhlich’s “credo,” particularly the areas of alignment and the friction point regarding ontology.

10.6 End of feedback

It is time to return to quantum mechanics. The approach I have been developing is a generalised probability theory where the quantum state sits on a complex of probability spaces. In my review post of October 2022 I referred to the work of Fröhlich and

colleagues and their search for a fundamental theory of quantum mechanics. They call it ETH (Events, Trees, and Histories) (Fröhlich 2021). There is also an approach that proposes that quantum mechanics is fundamentally probabilistic and that it describes events and not just measurements. So, I will, over several posts, work through their theory to learn how some of the gaps in my own approach may be addressed. The picture below gives an early indication how the concept of possibilities fit into the ETH scheme. An event is identified with the realisation of a possibility.

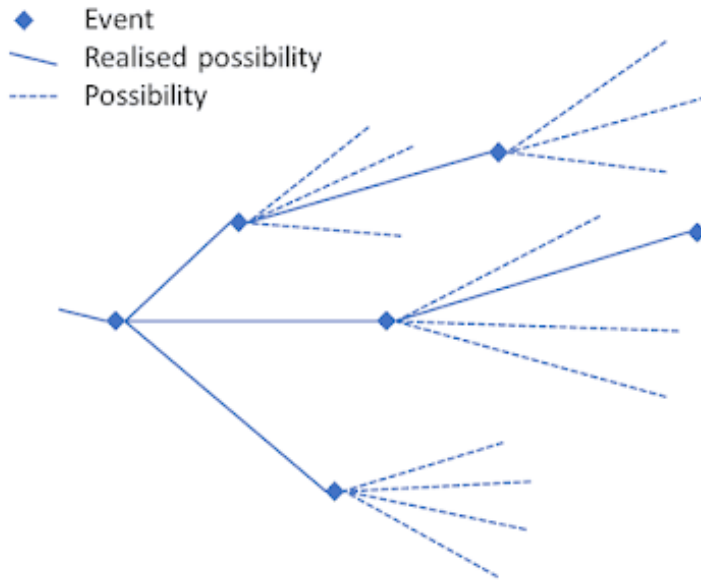


Figure 10.1: Illustration of ETH - Events, trees, and histories

It has been a theme of my posts to try and clarify the philosophical fundamentals, especially ontology, associated with a physical

theory. So, I will start the review of ETH with the introduction to a paper in which Fröhlich sets out his “credo” for his endeavour (Fröhlich 2021). His credo is:

! Fröhlich’s Credo

1. Talking of the “interpretation” of a physical theory presupposes implicitly that the theory has reached its final form, but that it is not completely clear, yet, what it tells us about natural phenomena. Otherwise, we had better speak of the “foundations” of the theory. Quantum Mechanics has apparently not reached its final form, yet. Thus, it is not really just a matter of interpreting it, but of completing its foundations.
2. The only form of “interpretation” of a physical theory that I find legitimate and useful is to delineate approximately the ensemble of natural phenomena the theory is supposed to describe and to construct something resembling a “structure-preserving map” from a subset of mathematical symbols used in the theory that are supposed to represent physical quantities to concrete physical objects and phenomena (or events) to be described by the theory. Once these items are clarified the theory is supposed to provide its own “interpretation”. (A good example is Maxwell’s electrodynamics, augmented by the special theory of relativity.)
3. The ontology a physical theory is supposed to capture lies in sequences of events, sometimes called “histories”, which form the objects of series of observations extending over possibly long stretches of time and which the theory is supposed to describe.
4. In discussing a physical theory and mathematical chal-

lenges it raises it is useful to introduce clear concepts and basic principles to start from and then use precise and – if necessary – quite sophisticated mathematical tools to formulate the theory and to cope with those challenges.

5. To emphasize this last point very explicitly, I am against denigrating mathematical precision and ignoring or neglecting precise mathematical tools in the search for physical theories and in attempts to understand them, derive consequences from them and apply them to solve concrete problems.

where I have added the numbering for easy reference. Let's take them one by one.

I agree completely with this comment although I may have lapsed occasionally into using the term “interpretation” loosely. So, a possibility to be investigated is that in addition to the standard formulation of quantum mechanics there may be an additional stochastic process that describes event histories.

The use of “interpreted” in the second paragraph has to do with the scope and meaning of the theory. We have the physical quantities that are to be described or explained, their mathematical representation and then the various theoretical structures that can make use of these quantities in their mathematical representation. In this way it should be clear from the outset what the intended theory is about. It about things and their mathematical representation.

This statement poses more of a problem. For me, the ontology has more to do with the concerns in the previous paragraph. While I agree that there are events, there must be physical quantities that participate in these events. These quantities must also form part

of the ontology. For example, atoms may be made up of more fundamental particles. The atoms and the more fundamental particle are part of the ontology, and it is part of the structure of the ontology that atoms are made up of electrons, protons, and neutrons. Neutrons and protons are made up of still more fundamental particles. I would also include fields and possible states of the physical objects in the ontology.

Again, I agree. Feynman is known to have said that doing science is to stop us fooling ourselves. He was thinking primarily of comparing predictions with the outcome of experiments. However, mathematics also plays this role. By formulating rigorously the mathematics of a theory and following strictly the consequences we can avoid introducing implicit assumptions that make things work out “all right” when they should not. When we get disagreement with experiment then we can be sure that it is the initial assumptions about objects or their mathematical representation that is at fault.

Fröhlich’s reputation is as an especially rigorous mathematical physicist and not only philosophers, but many physicists take such a rigorous approach to the mathematics to be rigorous for rigour’s sake. While I do not claim his skills, I am more than happy to try and learn from an approach that emphasises precise mathematics.

Within this “credo” Fröhlich and collaborators address:

- Why it is fundamentally impossible to use a physical theory to predict the future.
- Why quantum mechanics is probabilistic.
- The clarification of “locality” and “causality” in quantum mechanics.
- The nature of events.

- The evolution of states in space-time.
- The nature of space-time in quantum mechanics.

We will work our way through these topics in upcoming posts.

11 The Impossibility of Prediction and Quantum Indeterminacy

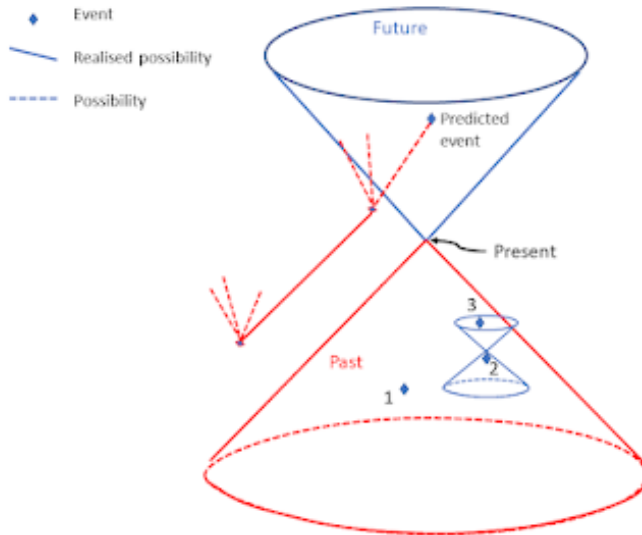
The previous post introduced the ETH (Events, Trees and Histories) approach to the foundations and completion of quantum theory. This post addresses why it is impossible to use a physical theory to predict the future and why quantum mechanics is probabilistic although the Schrödinger equation is deterministic.

Prediction uses available information to get knowledge about what will happen. It is an epistemic concept. The impossibility of prediction does not mean that the world is not deterministic, not governed by probabilistic law or even not governed by any laws at all. However, if we could predict the future reliably then this would be evidence that the world is deterministic. We will examine Fröhlich's (2021) arguments.

11.1 Impossibility of Prediction

It is always possible for someone to make a series of successful guesses about the future but what we are considering here is prediction based on available information and physical theory. To predict an event, we must know of everything that can affect that

event. That is what the event is and when and where it takes place. Fröhlich's [1] argument is simple and illustrated by the diagram below.



The diagram uses the standard light-cone representation of space-time. The Future is at the top and the Past at the bottom. The predictor sits at the Present and has in principle access to all information in their Past light-cone. That is, they can access information on all past events but no information on what happens outside their Past light-cone.

There is causal structure within the Past light-cone. Events 1 and 2 are space-like separated. They cannot influence each other. Event 3 is in the future of 2, so event 2 can influence 3. Of significance for the argument are the events outside the predictor's light-cones (Future and Past) that are in the past light-cone of

the predicted event. These events can influence what happens at the space-time point of the predicted event, but the predictor can have no knowledge of them. Therefore, the predictor cannot predict in principle what will happen at a future space-time point. In practice it is common knowledge that prediction is seen to work in many situations. These situations are controlled to isolate the predicted phenomenon from the influence outside the predictor's control.

11.2 Indeterminacy of Quantum Mechanics

The impossibility of reliable prediction does not imply indeterminacy.

Consider an isolated system. That is, over a period of time its evolution is independent of the rest of the universe. It is only for isolated physical systems that we know how to describe the time evolution of operators representing physical quantities in the Heisenberg picture (in terms of the unitary propagation of the system).

In the Heisenberg picture states of S are given by density matrices, ρ , acting on a separable Hilbert space, $\mathcal{H}$, of pure state vectors of S as in the mathematical formulation presented previously. Let $\hat{X}$ be a physical property of S , and let $X(t) = \hat{X}(t)^*$ be the self-adjoint linear operator on $\mathcal{H}$ representing $\hat{X}$ at time t . Then the operators $X(t)$ and $X(t')$ representing $\hat{X}$ at two different times t and t' , respectively, are related by a unitary transformation:

$$X(t) = U(t', t)X(t')U(t, t')$$

where, for each pair of times t, t' , $U(t, t')$ is the propagator (from t' to t) of the system S , which is a unitary operator acting on $\mathcal{H}$, and $\{U(t, t')\}_{t, t' \in \mathbb{R}}$ satisfy

$$\begin{aligned} U(t, t') \cdot U(t', t'') &= U(t, t''), \quad \forall t, t', t'' \\ U(t, t) &= 1, \quad \forall t \end{aligned}$$

However, in the Copenhagen interpretation, whenever a measurement is made, at some time t , say the deterministic unitary evolution of the state of S in the Schrödinger picture is interrupted, and the state collapses into an eigenspace of the self-adjoint operator representing the physical quantity that is measured and over that eigenspace the probabilities are given by Born's Rule. This is what we have previously called the selection of a σ -algebra from the σ -complex of S .

As I am working towards a formulation of quantum mechanics that does not give a special status to measurement or observers. In the post *Modal categories and quantum chance* Born's rule is invoked as follows:

The probability measure describes a contingent mode of being for the quantum system with a spectrum of values that are possible and become actual. What is missing is an understanding of the timing of the actualisation. In all the versions of quantum theory considered so far time behaves the same way as in classical physics.

While the question of timing is still to be resolved, quantum mechanics should be a theory that incorporates random events that are not derived from the deterministic evolution of the state. However, that evolution does govern the probabilities of becoming

actual of property values associated with the spectrum of the self-adjoint operators representing the physical properties of S .

It should be noted that Bohmian mechanics provides an alternative model in which the uncertainty of the outcome is due to uncertainty in the initial conditions for the dynamical evolution. In the Bohmian theory the uncertainty is epistemic, and the dynamics is deterministic. The Bohmian theory needs to introduce this uncertainty into an otherwise deterministic theory to obtain empirical equivalence to standard quantum mechanics.

The formulation of the quantum mechanics presented in this blog is, so far, consistent with the ETH approach [1]. Some aspects of special relativity have now been introduced even though a relativistic formulation of quantum mechanics has not been presented yet. This will be part of the formulation of a mathematical description of the quantum “event”.

12 Events in quantum mechanics: a simple proposal

In standard quantum mechanics, **events** are observations. The occurrence of an event typically requires an experimental setup; an actual observer appears only in thought experiments such as [Wigner's friend](#) or [Schrödinger's Cat](#). I do not deny that observing experimenters exist, but I claim they are not essential to the workings of the physical world. This note outlines a simple, local account of how events arise.

The [quantum pointer behind the two slits](#) in the interference experiment and the [Stern–Gerlach setup](#) with a magnetic field indicate that an interaction can select one σ -algebra from a σ -complex. Once a σ -algebra is selected, the postulate is that the associated probability distribution is sampled and that sample is an *event*.

This description looks classical in form even though it is expressed in quantum-state language. The magnetic field is treated classically as a parameter in the quantum Hamiltonian.

Experiments examined

- [Double slit interference](#)

- Stern–Gerlach

These examples motivate the algebra-selection plus sampling picture described below.

12.1 Proposal

A local interaction between a quantum system and an apparatus (pointer, Stern–Gerlach device, etc.) **selects a single σ -algebra** from a prior complex of possible algebras that describe the system’s properties. A **σ -algebra** denotes the set of measurable properties and their logical combinations that can be assigned probabilities. This selection occurs at the interaction and precedes macroscopic detection.

Once a single σ -algebra is selected, the situation admits a classical probability description. At that point an event may be modelled as a sample drawn from the resulting probability distribution, analogous to sampling in classical statistics. The actualisation of a potential value is caused by the interaction and is the immediate next step after the complex reduces to one algebra.

After this actualisation, the particle may proceed to a detector and its properties recorded in accord with the experiment’s purpose.

Toy model (two-level system coupled to a pointer)

A short, standard toy model makes the idea concrete.

- **System:** two-level system with orthonormal basis $\{|a_1\rangle, |a_2\rangle\}$.
- **Apparatus (pointer):** large Hilbert space with pointer states $|\phi\rangle$.
- **Interaction Hamiltonian (idealised von Neumann coupling):**

$$H_{\text{int}} = g \hat{A} \otimes \hat{P},$$

where $\hat{A}$ has eigenstates $|a_i\rangle$ with eigenvalues a_i , and $\hat{P}$ is the pointer momentum conjugate to the pointer position.

- **Initial state:**

$$|\Psi(0)\rangle = (c_1|a_1\rangle + c_2|a_2\rangle) \otimes |\phi_0\rangle.$$

- **After interaction** (unitary $U = \exp(-\frac{i}{\hbar}H_{\text{int}}t)$) the joint state becomes entangled:

$$|\Psi\rangle = c_1|a_1\rangle \otimes |\phi_1\rangle + c_2|a_2\rangle \otimes |\phi_2\rangle,$$

where $|\phi_i\rangle$ are pointer states correlated with system outcomes.

- **Reduced density matrix of the system:**

$$\rho_s = \text{Tr}_{\text{ptr}} |\Psi\rangle\langle\Psi| = \sum_{i,j} c_i c_j^* \langle\phi_j|\phi_i\rangle |a_i\rangle\langle a_j|.$$

If the pointer states become effectively orthogonal, $\langle\phi_j|\phi_i\rangle \approx \delta_{ij}$, then ρ_s is approximately diagonal in the $\{|a_i\rangle\}$ basis and the probabilities for outcomes are $p_i \approx |c_i|^2$.

Interpretation in the proposal. The interaction has singled out the algebra generated by the projectors $\{|a_i\rangle\langle a_i|\}$ (a σ -algebra of events for this measurement context). Once that algebra is selected, the classical probability distribution $\{p_i\}$ is available and the event is modelled as sampling that distribution: outcome i occurs with probability p_i .

This toy model shows how a local interaction can (i) pick a preferred algebra/basis and (ii) produce a classical probability distribution from which an event can be sampled.

12.2 Remarks and context

- **Relation to decoherence**

The algebra-selection step is closely related to decoherence: the apparatus (and environment) cause pointer states to become orthogonal, effectively selecting a preferred algebra or basis. The present outline emphasises that once such a basis is selected, one may treat the next step as classical sampling.

- **Measurement problem**

This account reframes measurement as (i) local algebra selection via interaction and decoherence, followed by (ii) sampling from the resulting classical distribution. It avoids invoking conscious observers while acknowledging that further work is needed to explain why a single sample is realised rather than only an effectively diagonal density matrix.

- **Wigner’s friend and observer-relativity**

If different observers assign different algebras, the proposal ties the algebra-selection to the local interaction that couples system and apparatus. Reconciling observer-relative descriptions with a single objective event requires further clarification.

- **Entanglement and Bell correlations**

A local algebra-selection mechanism must still reproduce Bell-type correlations. The global quantum state and the local selection rules together must yield the correct joint probabilities without superluminal causal influences; this is a key constraint on any full theory.

12.3 Development avenues

1. **Relativistic quantum theory**

Investigate Fröhlich’s relativistic quantum theory (Fröhlich 2021) to embed algebra selection and actualisation in a relativistic framework.

2. Branching mathematics

Study the mathematics of branching in Everettian (many-worlds) formulations. The multiverse formulation (Wallace 2012) has an event problem—how to interpret branching as events—and understanding branching may allow replacing universe splitting with sampling of a probability distribution over possibilities.

12.4 Suggested additions for a fuller manuscript

- Define terms briefly (e.g., σ -algebra, σ -complex, selection).
- Provide a worked toy model with explicit parameter choices and timescales.
- Compare explicitly with decoherence, objective collapse, and Everett interpretations.
- Identify any empirical differences or tests that could distinguish this outline from other accounts.

Part V

Psychic layer

1 Sensory order

This chapter will examine how the work of Hayek on emergent order can help develop the ontology of the Psychic level and clarify the relationship to the lower biological level and the higher Spiritual level.

- Hartmann develops a stratified ontology of reality (Seinsschichten), where higher levels emerge from but are irreducible to lower ones. As is explained in chapter [Strata of being](#).
- Hayek develops a theory of spontaneous orders and complex phenomena, also emphasizing irreducibility and emergent structures.

This comparative study focuses on:

- Emergence: Hartmann's categorial Novum vs. Hayek's complex phenomena.
- Layered ontology: Hartmann's strata vs. Hayek's multi-level social orders.
- Anti-reductionism: Both reject physicalist reductionism.
- Rules and categories: Hartmann's categories vs. Hayek's rules-based order.
- Realism: Both defend the reality of higher-order structures.

1.1 Emergence and layers

2 Hartmann and Hayek on layered reality

Both Nicolai Hartmann and Friedrich von Hayek defend a **stratified, anti-reductionist picture of reality**, but they do so from very different traditions. Hartmann works within realist phenomenology and critical ontology; Hayek comes from Austrian economics, theoretical psychology, and liberal social theory. Conceptually, however, they converge on three core ideas: **levels**, **emergence**, and **irreducibility**.

2.1 Ontological levels

- **Hartmann:** Reality is articulated into ontological strata (inorganic, organic, psychic, spiritual). Each level has its own categories and laws, and higher levels depend on but are not reducible to lower ones. The doctrine of *Schichtenbau der Welt* is explicitly ontological and systematic.
- **Hayek:** Reality—especially social and mental reality—is structured in levels of complexity. Markets, legal orders, and mental phenomena are higher-level “orders” generated by interactions at a lower level (individual actions, neural

events), but they cannot be exhaustively described in the language of those lower levels.

In both, **levels are not mere heuristic abstractions**; they mark genuine ontological differences.

2.2 Emergence and the “novum”

- **Hartmann:** Higher levels exhibit a *categorical novum*: new determinations and laws that do not appear at lower levels. Emergence is ontological, not just epistemic.
- **Hayek:** Complex phenomena (mind, market, law) display patterns that cannot be predicted or derived from micro-data alone. His notion of “spontaneous order” and his theory of complex phenomena imply that higher-level structures have properties not reducible to the properties of their elements.

Hartmann’s *novum* and Hayek’s “spontaneous order” are structurally similar: both mark **genuinely new properties** at higher levels.

2.3 Dependence and constraint

- **Hartmann:** Higher levels are **founded on** lower ones (Abhängigkeitsverhältnis): they require the lower level as a basis, yet possess their own autonomous laws. Dependence is asymmetric: the higher cannot exist without the lower, but the lower is not determined by the higher.

- **Hayek:** Higher-level orders **emerge from** lower-level interactions, but once in place they **constrain** and **channel** those interactions (e.g. rule-governed behaviour, price signals). The dependence is again asymmetric: no market without individuals, but individual actions are shaped by the market order.

Both thus combine **ontological dependence** with **relative autonomy** of higher levels.

2.4 Anti-reductionism

- **Hartmann:** Explicitly rejects both upward and downward reduction. Physicalism fails because it cannot capture the categorical novelties of life, consciousness, and spirit.
- **Hayek:** Rejects reduction of mental and social phenomena to physical or individual-psychological descriptions. His work in *The Sensory Order* and later social theory argues that different levels require **different conceptual frameworks**.

For both, anti-reductionism is not just methodological; it is grounded in a **metaphysics of levels**.

2.5 Rules, categories, and order

- **Hartmann:** Builds a systematic theory of categories: each level has its own categorical structure, and there are also “modal” and “formal” categories that cut across levels.

- **Hayek:** Develops a theory of **rules** (of just conduct, of social interaction) and **orders** (cosmos vs. taxis). Rules are not reducible to individual intentions; they form part of the structure of a higher-level order.

A fruitful analogy: Hartmann's **categories** and Hayek's **rules** both function as **structuring principles** of levels/orders.

2.6 Realism about higher-level entities

- **Hartmann:** Robust ontological realism: higher-level entities (organisms, persons, cultural formations) are real, not mere constructs.
- **Hayek:** Realist about social and mental orders: markets, legal systems, and traditions are not fictions; they are objective orders with their own regularities, even though they are unintended.

Both oppose any view that treats higher-level entities as merely “illusory” or “nothing but” lower-level facts.

2.7 Key differences

- **Systematicity:** Hartmann offers a fully systematic ontology; Hayek's ontology is fragmentary and embedded in psychology and social theory.

- **Normativity:** Hartmann's ontology is largely descriptive; Hayek's social ontology is tightly connected to normative liberalism (rule of law, limits of constructivist rationalism).
- **Method:** Hartmann proceeds via categorial analysis and phenomenological realism; Hayek via theory of complex phenomena, epistemic limits, and evolutionary accounts of institutions.

A comparative project can treat Hartmann as providing a **general metaphysical framework** within which Hayek's emergentist social ontology can be located and clarified.

Part VI

Spiritual layer

1 Ontological Critiques of the Notion of Government

1.1 Introduction

This overview surveys several major **ontological critiques of the concept of government**.

Unlike political or moral critiques, ontological critiques question the *being, existence, or metaphysical status* of government as such. These critiques arise from different philosophical traditions, each challenging the assumption that “government” is a coherent or real entity.

The four strongest traditions are:

1. **Anti-entity / nominalist critiques**
2. **Process-ontology critiques**
3. **Social-constructivist critiques**
4. **Normative-ontological (anarchist metaphysics) critiques**

Each section below outlines the core argument and cites representative authors.

1.2 Anti-Entity Critiques: Government as a Reified Abstraction

A classical ontological critique holds that “government” is not a real entity but a **reified abstraction**.

On this view, only individuals exist; collective entities such as “the state” or “the government” are conceptual fictions.

Max Stirner famously described such abstractions as “*spooks*”—phantoms that dominate human thought despite lacking real existence (Stirner 1844).

Similarly, methodological individualists argue that social wholes cannot possess agency or intention independent of the individuals composing them (Hayek 1948).

This critique denies the ontological status of government altogether:

if only individuals exist, then attributing will, authority, or moral standing to “government” is a category mistake.

1.3 Process-Ontology Critiques: Government as a Set of Practices

A second critique arises from **process philosophy** and **social ontology**.

Here, government is not a substance or entity but a **dynamic ensemble of practices, relations, and performances**.

Michel Foucault’s work on *governmentality* treats governing as a historically contingent set of techniques rather than the action of a unified entity (Foucault 2007).

Bruno Latour's actor-network theory similarly dissolves institutions into networks of heterogeneous actors (Latour 2005).

Judith Butler extends this to political structures more broadly, arguing that political forms are performative and contingent (Butler 2015).

If government is a process rather than a thing, then it cannot serve as the bearer of sovereignty or authority.

Its ontological instability undermines claims to inherent legitimacy.

1.4 Social-Constructivist Critiques: Government as a Status Function

A third critique accepts that government exists, but only as a **socially constructed status function**.

John Searle argues that institutions exist because people collectively accept certain rules and assignments of function (Searle 1995).

However, this dependence on collective intentionality makes government **ontologically fragile**.

Charles Tilly's historical work shows that states emerged from contingent patterns of coercion and capital accumulation, not from any essential or natural form (Tilly 1992).

Benedict Anderson's analysis of nations as *imagined communities* extends this fragility to the political identities that sustain governments (Anderson 1983).

On this view, government has no mind-independent existence; its being is parasitic on shared belief and recognition.

1.5 Normative-Ontological Critiques: The Incoherence of Political Authority

The strongest analytic critique comes from **normative ontology**: government claims rights (to coerce, command, tax, punish) that no individual possesses.

If individuals lack these rights, then aggregating them cannot create such rights.

Robert Paul Wolff argues that political authority is incompatible with individual autonomy (Wolff 1970).

A. John Simmons shows that no existing theory successfully grounds a duty to obey the state (Simmons 1979).

Michael Huemer provides the most systematic contemporary version, arguing that the state's special moral status is a metaphysical fiction (Huemer 2013).

This critique concludes that government is **ontologically impossible** as a bearer of legitimate authority.

1.6 Conclusion

These four traditions—nominalist, process-ontological, constructivist, and normative-ontological—offer powerful challenges to the metaphysical coherence of “government.”

They differ in method and emphasis, but all converge on a central insight:

The concept of government is far less ontologically secure than political theory typically assumes.

Whether government is a fiction, a process, a fragile construct, or a metaphysical impossibility, each critique destabilises the idea that government is a natural or necessary feature of social reality.

Part VII

End

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